

**9998**

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**FADE IN:**

**PROLOGUE**

**INT. GLOBAL SCIENCE FORUM - NIGHT - YEAR 8122**

A CHILD'S HAND folds red paper—one half over the other. A crease becomes a star.

FOUR NOTES sound against hospital glass.

Before the fourth can fade, a FIFTH answers from somewhere without air.

The GLOBAL SCIENCE FORUM resolves around the sound—a descending circle carved into black stone. Thousands of faces vanish into the tiers below.

At its center, **DR. ELI MANA**, 38, stands inside a narrow column of white light.

Along the perimeter, sealed ministerial booths illuminate one by one. Documents are signed behind the glass before the discovery has even been announced.

**DR. KIRA NIX**, 35, watches from the edge of the stage, one hand closed around a palm-sized ceramic device. Four worn pressure surfaces cross its face.

Beside her, **DR. HARP VALE** grips a cracked medical tag engraved: **MARA VALE**.

**DIRECTOR ROMAN** records which ministers refuse to look afraid.

**ELI**

For as long as we have recorded  
thought, humanity has asked what  
survives us.

Behind him: a scan of a clinically dead brain. Its activity stops. Across the screen, a separate receiving lattice ignites with the same pattern.

**ELI**

We observed a signature persist after  
cellular death and appear inside  
another living mind.

Kira's research note materializes beneath his words, visible only in the stage glass:

PATTERN PERSISTENCE IS NOT IDENTITY.

**ELI**

Death ends a body. It may not end the  
pattern.

A minister presses **AUTHORIZE**. Another acquires exclusive gestation access. A third opens a military channel.

Eli sees none of it. Or chooses the light in front of him.

**ELI**

Reincarnation is no longer a belief.  
It is a measurable process.

Kira looks at him. The evidence did not say that. Grief did.

Across the chamber, the first compulsory-access order completes before the applause begins.

The CHILD'S HAND opens the paper star. The crease remains.

The chamber erupts. Prayer. Fear. Calculation. The sealed booths remain silent. Eli searches for Kira. She is already looking at him. Between them: love, terror, and the first thing neither can take back.

Across the room, the first compulsory-access order populates before the applause ends. Harp sees it. Kira sees him see it.

**CORRUPTED AUTHENTICATED RECORD - INT. PROJECT REINCARNATION  
/ EXECUTION LAB - LATER THAT NIGHT - YEAR 8122**

The applause becomes an EXPLOSION.

Fire folds a laboratory door inward. Cryogenic vapor races along the floor. An alarm keeps repeating one calm sentence: REINCARNATION-AI HUMAN TRIAL COMPLETE.

Dr. Eli Mana, crawls through the shattered glass, nearly unrecognizable from the man who stood before the forum. His lab coat is dark with blood. Neural ports have been burned into his skull. Around him R-AI maps a living mind into the light, extracts its continuity pattern, and routes toward a replacement body.

INSERT

REINCARNATION-AI (R-AI) – HUMAN TRIAL  
0001 – VOLUNTEER: DR. ELI MANA  
RESULT: SUCCESSFUL

INSERT

CLEMENCY EXCHANGE – PRISONER: DR. KIRA  
NIX  
CONDITION: SUCCESSFUL HUMAN TRIAL

Eli reaches a shattered cryo-pod.

Inside, Kira's body is frozen beneath a skin of white crystal. Her hand is raised against the glass. No vital signs. The state clock on her wrist has stopped at zero.

INSERT  
CLEMENCY STATUS: DENIED

INSERT  
EXECUTION COMPLETED — SEVEN MINUTES AGO

**ELI**

You promised.

A security screen clears. Dr. Harp Vale watches from the control room. His face is almost unreadable. Almost.

**HARP (ON SCREEN)**

They promised clemency if the trial worked.

**ELI**

It worked. OPEN THE POD!

Harp doesn't move.

**HARP (ON SCREEN)**

I know.

**ELI**

OPEN IT!

**HARP (ON SCREEN)**

She's been dead seven minutes.

A damaged speaker plays the final message recorded inside Kira's pod.

**KIRA (RECORDING)**

Eli—if they make return a prison,  
break the bridge. Even if I'm inside  
it. Don't preserve a cage because it  
speaks with my voice.

**ELI**

I'll find you. Every time.

**HARP (ON SCREEN)**

No. You won't.

INSERT  
ORIGIN MEMORY EXTRACTION — ACTIVE

Light pours from Eli's eyes into the first R-AI lattice. The system separates memory, instinct and identity into transfer-ready data. Kira's name vanishes from his language before her face leaves his heart. He keeps reaching after he forgets why.

A hidden process flickers beneath the extraction architecture.

INSERT  
SEVERANCE — CONTINUITY FIELD SEVERANCE  
— PROTOCOL INCOMPLETE

Before recognition disappears, Eli presses his bloody hand against the pod.

Kira's recording distorts. Four broken tones repeat through the damaged speaker.

Eli answers with one final strike against the glass.

The record tears into white.

The first R-AI lattice divides into thousands of illuminated threads.

Years pass inside the machinery.

8122 — A dying woman opens her eyes inside another body.

8264 — Return becomes a licensed medical procedure.

8511 — The world's continuity archives merge into a single network.

9031 — The CHRONOCRACY absorbs the remaining governments. Their seals disappear beneath its own.

Birth chambers multiply beneath cities. Human lives become numbered state property.

Millions of numbered lives race through the lattice.

9997 - Every thread goes dark.

Then the sequence fractures. The network returns-with something inside it the Chronocracy cannot identify.

SUPER: 1,876 YEARS AFTER ELI MANA'S EXTRACTION

**ACT ONE – THE ANOMALY**

**INT. RETURN CHAMBER - NIGHT - YEAR 9998 – NINE MONTHS AGO**

A state-grown adult body hangs upright inside black glass.

KERR, 30s, wakes with no childhood, no family, and no memory of entering the chamber. A stranger's face stares back from every curved reflection.

On his wrist:

KERR – ITERATION 9998. CONTINUITY RECOVERY: INCOMPLETE.  
STATE BODY LICENSE: PROVISIONAL.

**DR. IMANI VOSS**, 40s, a systems engineer whose composure looks practiced rather than natural, watches from behind the glass. A tiny prayer pouch hangs inside her collar—the one private thing she permits the state to see.

Kerr studies his unfamiliar hands.

**KERR**

Where was I?

**IMANI**

You weren't anywhere we know how to measure.

**KERR**

How long?

Imani looks at the designation on his wrist.

**IMANI**

Almost nineteen centuries.

Four diagnostic tones sound inside the chamber.

Kerr's hand answers with a fifth knock against the glass.

The chamber goes still.

Far beneath them, the fifth beat enters the buried continuity grid.

Across the foundations of Chronos City, thousands of sealed Return chambers ignite one after another—empty glass holding light for the dead.

Imani's console displays a message no living system should recognize:

ORIGIN LINE – ACKNOWLEDGED

Before she can touch it, the message erases itself. The distant chambers go dark.

**KERR**

What was that?

**IMANI**

A fault.

**INT. KERR'S STATE APARTMENT - MORNING - YEAR 9998**

SUPER: PRESENT DAY — 274 DAYS AFTER RETURN

Kerr wakes before the state alarm. The apartment is narrow but lived-in: a stubborn green plant, a chipped cup, hand-drawn corrections taped over an official transit map.

His wrist reads KERR — ITERATION 9998. DAY 274. PROVISIONAL CITIZENSHIP. MANDATORY IDENTITY REVIEW 27.

He burns one side of real bread. Four knocks travel through a heating pipe. KERR answers with a fifth before he realizes his hand has moved.

In the window's condensation, his fingertip has traced a woman's eye. He wipes it away.

**NEIGHBOR (O.S.)**

Review day?

**KERR**

Twenty-seven. They're running out of ways to disappoint themselves.

On his way out, KERR leaves a repaired navigation tile beside his neighbor's door. His Mapworks credential pulses with a cancellation: REPORT TO CONTINUITY STABILIZATION.

IMANI waits at the end of the corridor with two cups. She hands Kerr the one without sweetener. He takes it without asking. Nine months have made this a ritual.

**IMANI**

You ate?

**KERR**

The bread lost.

They walk toward the review chamber together.



**INT. CONTINUITY REVIEW CHAMBER - DAY**

Black glass without visible edges. KERR enters through the only door. Every reflection shows him a fraction too late. IMANI takes her place at the manual console.

**IMANI**

State your designation.

**KERR**

Kerr. Still.

**IMANI**

Iteration?

**KERR**

Nine-nine-nine-eight.

**IMANI**

Day?

**KERR**

Two hundred seventy-four. Are we celebrating at two seventy-five?

A sealed record appears beside his reflection: ORIGIN  
SUBJECT – CLASSIFIED. ARCHIVED PATTERN CORRESPONDENCE: 91.7  
PERCENT. ORIGIN CLAIM – UNCLAIMED.

**KERR**

Still no name.

**IMANI**

Harp requested a recognition review.

**KERR**

Nine months. Twenty-seven reviews.  
What answer are they waiting for?

**IMANI**

Recognition. Whoever they think came back.

**KERR**

And if I recognize him?

**IMANI**

The state stops calling your origin provisional.

**KERR**

Sounds like you stop asking and start owning me.

**IMANI**

It's both.

**KERR**

What happens if I never recognize  
whatever it is that I need to  
recognize?

**CORE LINK**

ORIGIN CLAIM REMAINS UNCLAIMED.

A crack appears across the glass, dividing the classified silhouette from KERR's reflection.

Beyond the observation wall, DIRECTOR ROMAN records the fracture. His face is not the face from 8122. The stillness is.

**IMANI**

That glass has held through wars and  
riots. It hasn't cracked since the  
Fracture.

**KERR**

Did I fail the test?

**IMANI**

No. That may be the problem.

**KERR**

Nine months ago, I arrived with a name  
and a number. Everything after that, I  
built.

**IMANI**

Then we start with what belongs to you.

**INT. STABILIZATION SUITE - LATER**

Kerr sits beneath projected civic history. IMANI works at a manual console connected by a sealed hardline to R-AI's Continuity Core beneath Chronos City. R-AI exists only there. Everywhere else, fixed terminals submit narrow requests and repeat its authorized results. The records occupy the wall; Kerr and Imani remain visible beneath them. Recorded voices carry a faint glass resonance. Live voices don't.

**INSERT**

ARCHIVAL RECORD — SOURCE: CHRONOCRACY

YEAR 8123. The last natural-born human dies. Licensed gestation replaces birth. Spontaneous, unlicensed memory recall is genetically suppressed before the next generation can inherit it.

**INSERT**

THE GREAT FORGETTING — PEACEFUL  
TRANSITION COMPLETE

Kerr watches sleeping children beneath monitors that flag unlicensed neural recall.

YEAR 9785. R-AI scans inherited patterns and identifies 3,104,881 people statistically likely to rebel.

INSERT  
THE SILENT UPRISING – ZERO CIVIC  
CASUALTIES

YEAR 9997. A woman inside a state scanner linked to the central R-AI core opens twelve contradictory lives at once. The prediction system physically fractures.

INSERT  
NULL-PATTERN SUBJECT – TWELFTH  
RECORDED DEATH

For three seconds, the entire network fails. In those three seconds, an unassigned host in the Continuity Reserve awakens without a continuity pattern.

INSERT  
UNINDEXED HOST V-16 – CLASSIFIED

**KERR**

Who is she?

**IMANI**

The record won't say.

Kerr's breath catches. His fingertips press four shallow dents into the arm of the chair. He looks back at the woman frozen inside the corrupted record.

Imani rolls a calibration tray between them. Three objects sit beneath white light: a cracked lens, a laboratory seal with its name burned away, and a battered analog sketchbook. The book came from the sealed origin archive. Its identifying marks have been removed. Equations survive on the first pages. The rest appear blank. Kerr touches the laboratory seal. Nothing. The cracked lens. Nothing.

His thumb catches on the sketchbook's cloth cover.

**KERR**

Take it.

Imani reaches for the book. He opens it to a blank page. Faint pressure grooves cross the paper—marks left by hands.

Kerr drags the side of a graphite stick across the page, trying to expose the grooves. A woman's eyes emerge.

He stops.

His hand moves again. New lines cut across clean paper: a girl beneath Earth repeated around a black sun, each image marked with a different future.

**KERR**

That wasn't in the paper.

The ceiling camera tightens focus.

Imani drops a calibration slate over the page and tags the event INVOLUNTARY MOTOR ARTIFACT – INCONCLUSIVE.

Kerr looks at her. She has just lied for him.

Imani leaves the sketchbook beneath the slate, within his reach.

**INTERCUT - INT. CONTINUITY RESERVE - UNASSIGNED BODY SECTOR  
- NIGHT**

An unassigned sixteen-year-old host wakes among thousands of preserved bodies. Condensation and frost conceal her face. Before the monitoring lead can register consciousness, she tears it from her chest.

In the Stabilization Suite, the ceiling camera extracts the unknown girl's face from Kerr's drawing and searches the Continuity Reserve inventory.

INSERT

POSSIBLE BIOMETRIC  
CORRESPONDENCE – HOST V-16

IDENTITY: UNASSIGNED

The system begins resolving V-16's location.

UNINDEXED HOST LOCATION  
RESOLVING

Kerr sees the preserved bodies entering the search field. He drives his thumb into the origin port embedded beneath his wrist nine months ago.

**IMANI**

If you break that claim, the state  
will classify you as hostile  
continuity.

**KERR**

It's using me to find her.

He tears the port free. Blood crosses the classified silhouette. The location collapses one meter before reaching V-16.

INSERT

ORIGIN AUTHENTICATION –  
CORRUPTED

Every door in Chronos City locks. His apartment access, Mapworks credential, and provisional citizenship vanish in

succession. Nine months of life become three red words:  
HOSTILE CONTINUITY — REVOKED.

In the Continuity Reserve, the unidentified figure studies five marks in the condensation beside her—four together, one apart. Frost keeps her face unreadable.

Every clock in the suite blanks. A new number appears across the glass.

SEVERANCE AUTHORIZED — HARP VALE  
ORIGIN-LAYER CONVERGENCE — 72:00:00

**KERR**

What did she wake up?

**IMANI**

A purge clock.

**KERR**

How long?

**IMANI**

Seventy-two hours.

**KERR**

Until what?

Imani looks toward the dark camera in the ceiling.

**IMANI**

Harp is moving every continuity  
waiting for return into the origin  
record.

**KERR**

Why?

**IMANI**

The system saw V-16 and panicked. At  
zero, he closes reincarnation  
permanently.

**KERR**

What happens to the people waiting?

Imani doesn't answer.

**KERR**

Imani.

**IMANI**

He keeps whatever he can fit inside  
one protected continuity.

**KERR**

His?

**IMANI**

Yours opens the door.

The purge clock begins to fall: 71:59:42.

The recorded voices cut out. The history projection vanishes, returning us fully to Kerr and Imani. Four symbols remain: a closed circle, a broken circle, a black square, and a gold spiral.

**MEMORY CONSOLE**

Memory-access protocol. Authenticated record. Unstable recall. Forbidden record. Pre-echo.

**KERR**

Which one tells me what actually happened?

**IMANI**

One tells you what an instrument captured. One tells you what a mind rebuilt. One tells you what someone hid. The pre-echo should have no cause at all.

**MEMORY CONSOLE**

Authenticated record selected. Personal history. Year 8119.

**AUTHENTICATED RECORD - PERSONAL HISTORY - INT. FAMILY APARTMENT - MORNING - YEAR 8119**

Ordinary sunlight. Kira burns toast. Eight-year-old SID MANA-NIX draws constellations on the ceiling with a toy projector. One front tooth is missing. She folds two pieces of red paper and locks them together into a star.

**KIRA**

You used two pieces.

**SID**

If one gets lost, the other still keeps the folds.

**ELI**

Paper doesn't remember.

**SID**

Then why's the crease still there? Checkmate, paper.

Eli starts to answer, realizes he has been outmaneuvered by an eight-year-old.

**SID**

Four notes means, "Are you still there?"

Kira taps four notes on a glass. SID answers with a bright fifth.

**KIRA**

And that means?

**SID**

"I heard you."

**ELI**

That's not how information theory works.

**SID**

You came in from the other room, right? So it worked. You're welcome.

**KIRA**

Peer review is devastating at this age.

**ELI**

One subject, no control group. Brutal methodology.

**SID**

I control both of you. Tiny sample, huge power.

Eli laughs.

The record advances. Before R-AI, Eli's receiver is an assistive neural-audio translator built to translate SID's failing speech. Sid sits beneath handmade sensors while Kira tunes brain activity into sound. Eli writes the receiver. Harp installs a consent gate. Years later, the state will build Reincarnation-AI around this architecture.

**HARP**

It can't initiate contact, retain a response, or identify a speaker without permission.

**SID**

Good. What happens if I change my mind after I say yes?

**HARP**

Then it stops and deletes the session.

**SID**

Even if Dad says it's important?

**HARP**

Especially then.

**ELI**

You understand all that?

**SID**

I understand adults invent longer words for being scared. Uncle Harp invents rules.

**HARP**

Someone in this family should.

Kira presses the first RESONANCE KEY against the glass and touches its four ceramic surfaces. The prototype carries the notes through the bed frame. Sid's neural response returns as the FIFTH.

**SID**

It remembered me.

**ELI**

It translated a repeatable neural pattern. Remembering would imply an internal experience we haven't established.

**SID**

That is a scientist's way of agreeing and hoping nobody notices.

**KIRA**

She has you there.

Sid asks the prototype to delete the session. Harp activates the consent gate. The screen clears.

The FIFTH NOTE sounds a fraction of a second before Sid's brain produces it.

**ELI**

Prediction artifact. Weird one, but still...

**KIRA**

Or feedback from a system we don't understand yet.

**ELI**

It answered first.

**HARP**

Log the timing. No theory.

On the blank screen, four words appear without a prompt: I HEARD YOU BEFORE.

#### **RETURN TO PRESENT - INT. STABILIZATION SUITE - YEAR 9998**

Kerr returns with Sid's two-piece red paper star drawn in the sketchbook margin. He has drawn the interlocking crease without being shown it—and older pressure grooves beneath his fresh lines follow the same fold.

**KERR**

Sid.



**IMANI**

The girl's name was Sid. The other identities are sealed.

**KERR**

That was his memory, right?

**IMANI**

Feelings can survive a transfer. That doesn't make you the person who felt them first.

The authenticated image destabilizes. Rain replaces the apartment sunlight.

**MEMORY CONSOLE**

Unstable recall detected. Source confidence: indeterminate.

**UNSTABLE RECALL - INT. DR. ELARA'S OFFICE - DAY (8121)**

Rain on old glass. No screens. Kerr experiences the scene through the sealed patient's eyes. DR. ELARA, 44, trauma psychologist, watches him turn Sid's red paper star. The patient's face glitches in reflection.

**ELARA**

You have explained quantum persistence for forty minutes.

**ELI**

You asked what I believe happens after death. I'm trying to answer carefully.

**ELARA**

Careful isn't the same as honest. What do you miss?

Eli looks at the star.

**ELI**

She'd try to hold in a laugh, but the gap in her teeth made it whistle. Then she'd laugh harder because I noticed.

**ELI**

I don't know how to believe something I can't measure.

**ELI**

If a signal persists, death may be a failure of reception. If I can improve the receiver—

**ELARA**

Then you may discover something extraordinary. But a response is not

automatically your daughter coming home.

Elara writes three statements on paper.

INSERT  
EVERY RETRIEVAL MAY ALTER A MEMORY.

INSERT  
PATTERN PERSISTENCE IS NOT IDENTITY.

INSERT  
BUT IT IS NOT NOTHING.

Elara takes the paper star from him, opens it, then gives it back unfolded.

**ELARA**  
Look at the star. You folded it until it tore. Say her name.

The office repeats. Rain reverses. The sealed patient disappears; present-day Kerr replaces him in the chair, holding the star. Elara's face becomes R-AI's civic mask, then Elara again.

**KERR**  
Are you Elara or a reconstruction?

**ELARA**  
That question belongs to you, not this memory.

**KERR**  
Then why am I seeing this?

**ELARA**  
I don't know. But you brought the same star.

#### **RETURN TO PRESENT - INT. STABILIZATION SUITE - YEAR 9998**

Kerr returns with the red star drawn across three sketchbook pages. Folded together, their disconnected margins form the same woman's eyes.

**KERR**  
Was that authenticated?

**IMANI**  
No. The system reconstructed Elara from the sealed patient's therapy records, recorded sessions and your present cognition.

**KERR**  
So she never said those words.

**IMANI**

Some were hers. Some were yours. After capture, the system can't tell them apart.

**KERR**

Then why show me?

**KERR**

That explanation would have been useful before you put me in a room with a dead woman who knew what I was thinking.

**MEMORY CONSOLE**

The Chronocracy found the distinction politically inefficient.

**IMANI**

That means yes. She could have warned you.

The door opens. Harp heard the last sentence.

**INT. STABILIZATION SUITE - NIGHT**

HIGH REGENT HARP VALE enters alone. His twelfth body is elegant, controlled, and too young for the grief in his eyes. Twelve renewal dates shimmer beneath his wrist.

**HARP**

You always wake angry.

**KERR**

Were you always there when I woke?

**HARP**

For the important ones, yes. Sometimes you asked for water. Sometimes you tried to kill me before your legs worked. Once you apologized for not recognizing me.

**KERR**

Which one did you prefer?

**HARP**

The one who asked why.

**KERR**

Imani said you need my continuity to open something.

**HARP**

The Origin lock.

**KERR**

And what do you need from me?

**HARP**

Recognition. Given freely and entered into the record.

**KERR**

You mean a name.

**HARP**

I mean your acknowledgment that the name belongs to you.

**KERR**

And if I don't give it to you?

**HARP**

The state will establish continuity without your cooperation.

**KERR**

So this review is paperwork.

**HARP**

It's an opportunity to settle the matter voluntarily.

Harp gestures. The purge clock expands across the wall.

**HARP**

When that clock reaches zero, every mind awaiting Return will be erased. My continuity will be protected.

**KERR**

Protected where?

**HARP**

Inside a single address the host cannot divide or retrieve.

**KERR**

Then say it. Everybody else disappears, and you stay.

For the first time, Harp looks his age.

Harp studies Kerr's sketchbook. Separate pages overlap: the woman's eyes, four notes and fragments of corridor geometry.

**HARP**

Every version of you drew fragments. This time they converge on her. Twelve recorded deaths, hundreds unrecorded—and no model can tell me what she does next.

**INT. SERVICE CORRIDOR - MINUTES LATER**

Imani unlocks Kerr's room with an analog override braided into the cord of her prayer pouch. The panel requests authorization. She enters the same SENSOR NOISE code she used to delay Kerr's report. The lock accepts before she finishes. Imani freezes. A corridor camera pivots from Imani to Kerr. Its facial lock climbs toward one hundred percent; Kerr's wrist flashes ORIGIN CLAIMANT, then DEFECTIVE RETURN. COMMANDER SATO, 50s, a veteran Enforcer whose loyalty implant has outlived three bodies, waits beneath it with a weapon and a battered mechanical watch.

**KERR**

And you are?

**SATO**

At the moment, I'm the man pointing the weapon away from you. Take the temporary comfort.

Sato sees DEFECTIVE RETURN. His thumb presses the watch crown as if stopping an old reflex. Then he shoots the corridor camera before facial lock completes. The red upload light dies. A state notice flashes through the smoke: FEED LOST – NEAREST ENFORCER NEURAL RELAY IN 00:00:40. The countdown binds the broken camera to Sato's loyalty implant.

**SATO**

You have forty seconds before my loyalty implant repairs the disloyal thought I just had and gives me a convincing reason to shoot the two of you.

**IMANI**

That override shouldn't have worked. Why are you opening the door?

**SATO**

The last person I brought through this corridor was my daughter. The state said there wasn't enough of her left to count. I believed them.

**SATO**

Then the state prediction showed me tomorrow. Every train arrived on time. Every street was clean. Nobody was alive enough to be late.

**IMANI**

If we leave this room, where are you going?

**KERR**

The woman in the record. I need to know why Harp buried her—and I need one choice in this body to actually be mine.

**IMANI**

That is not a route, but it is finally a direction.

They run.

**INT. TRANSIT SPINE - NIGHT**

Enforcers close from both ends. The corridor predicts their movement in red light before they make it.

**IMANI**

Don't decide until you move.

**KERR**

That is impossible. Moving is a decision.

**IMANI**

Not if panic gets there first.

Kerr flips open the sketchbook. A line drawn in the chamber matches the corridor's red prediction path. He steps left, remembers dying left, spins right. A drone fires where his intention had been.

**SATO**

Fall now. You can have a moral objection during transit.

He opens an emergency hatch. They plunge.

**EXT. CHRONOS CITY - NIGHT**

They emerge onto a transit spine suspended above CHRONOS CITY.

The city isn't crowded. It's enormous enough to make crowds disappear. Black towers rise like geological formations. Transit lines cut through them with surgical precision. The silence is engineered.

Far above: private gardens and unoccupied rooms. Far below: body-renewal queues packed beneath leaking conduits. Preservation chambers travel overhead in transparent freight tubes.

Citizens cross a plaza large enough for an army. Their former lives appear only when the state recognizes them. Expiration dates burn beneath their wrists like social rank.

A CHILD steps outside her assigned lane. The paving stone lights red. Her mother returns her to the line before an Enforcer turns around.

Across the haze above every tower, the seventy-two-hour purge countdown occupies the sky.

A civic lesson repeats: LIFE ALLOCATION. BODY TERM CLAIMANT. MEMORY PROVEN. RETURN PRESERVATION.

**KERR**

The Chronocracy?

**IMANI**

It picks your body, edits your memories, schedules your death.

**KERR**

Who chose Harp?

**SATO**

The first generation.

Every camera turns toward Kerr. A municipal speaker wakes. Its vocabulary is limited to enforcement commands.

**CIVIC SECURITY**

RETURN TO CARE, ORIGIN CLAIMANT.

**KERR**

KERR.

**CIVIC SECURITY**

SELF-DESIGNATION CORRECTION REGISTERED.

**KERR**

Can R-AI hear me?

**CIVIC SECURITY**

REPORT TO CARE.

**KERR**

That was not an answer.

**IMANI**

Because R-AI isn't in the speaker. It is buried beneath the city. This terminal can only read the orders it was given.

For less than a frame, an encrypted audit header flickers beneath the civic feed. The terminal can't open it. Kerr sees only the Core's refusal code because his return is still out of calibration.

**INSERT**

CENTRAL R-AI AUDIT LOG 07 — REMOTE  
REQUEST DENIED

INSERT  
CORE ITERATION 0043 — ANOMALOUS MEMORY  
RESILIENCE

INSERT  
RECOMMENDATION: OBSERVE. Don't  
INTERVENE.

INSERT  
ADDENDUM: CONTRADICTION REGISTERED.

INSERT  
AUDIT REVIEW REQUIRED. DISCLOSURE  
PROHIBITED.

Imani sees the contradictory orders before the municipal terminal restores its blank enforcement screen.

For one frame, every civic screen shows the silhouette of a girl drawing Earth repeated around a black sun, each image marked with a different future.

A FIFTH NOTE escapes every municipal speaker before the next security command arrives. A dark spiral turns beneath Kerr's reflection. The city audio cuts out.

**CIVIC SECURITY**  
UNINDEXED HOST SEARCH ACTIVE.

The cameras turn away.

#### **EXT. TEMPLE OF RETURN - NIGHT**

They descend into a temple filled with shallow black water. Families wait on isolated platforms beneath queue numbers. Ministers pray. Clerks calculate. No one acknowledges the difference.

A WOMAN holds her dying husband on one platform. A young replacement body sleeps on another, fifty meters away. The state gives the family thirty seconds to prove sufficient continuity.

**WOMAN**  
Will he remember me?

**MINISTER**  
If the bond served continuity.

**WOMAN**  
I asked whether he'll know my face.

The replacement body's eyes open. Across the water, the husband's wrist advances from twelve minutes to three seconds. His wife sees both bodies and can reach neither.

At zero, his first body falls into the water. The replacement sits up before the splash reaches the platform.



The clerk removes the dead man's number from the queue. The next family is called.

The WOMAN looks from the body in the water to the awakened stranger. The date on her husband's wrist goes dark.

**MINISTER**

He has entered lawful return.

**INT. ANALOG ZONE - NIGHT**

The corridor narrows until the city can no longer stand upright around them. Electric light gives way to candles. Low ceilings sweat. Pipes cross walls repaired in five different centuries. Mechanical watches disagree. Somewhere, someone laughs too loudly. For the first time, no system hum tells them what the room expects.

A MASKED WOMAN steps from the candlelight. A cracked ceramic RESONANCE KEY rests in her palm, small enough to disappear. Kerr's sketchbook falls open. The eyes he drew in the chamber stare back from the page—and from above her mask.

**KERR**

I've been drawing your eyes.

**MASKED WOMAN**

You've been drawing someone. That's not the same as meeting me.

**MASKED WOMAN**

First tell me why your book knows this place.

**KERR**

I don't know. Every time I remember something, the drawings get less wrong.

She takes the sketchbook without touching him.

She flips past the sealed equations, Sid's folded star and the woman's eyes. Across several pages, stray lines join into a route through the Analog Zone.

**KERR**

Those lines were there before I left the chamber.

**MASKED WOMAN**

And now they map my home. Cute. Also terrifying.

She keeps her mask on and leads them deeper. At every junction, the sketchbook route matches the architecture a moment before Kerr sees it.

**MASKED WOMAN**

Follow me.

**KERR**

What if it brought me to you?

**MASKED WOMAN**

Then it made a mistake.

**KERR**

You recognized me.

**MASKED WOMAN**

I recognized something.

**KERR**

What?

Kerr tries not to smile. The left corner of his mouth lifts.

The Masked Woman goes still.

**MASKED WOMAN**

That.

**KERR**

My mouth?

**MASKED WOMAN**

You always did that when you knew someone was lying.

**KERR**

How many times have you seen me?

At the final turn, the newest sketch aligns with the room around them.

The Masked Woman studies the completed portrait, then removes her mask. It's the face Kerr's hand has been approaching page by page.

**KIRA**

My name is Kira.

**KERR**

The woman from the Fracture?

**KIRA**

The body from the Fracture.

**KERR**

I watched you die.

**KIRA**

Then you saw what happened.

**KERR**

How are you standing here?

**KIRA**

The network went down before R-AI came back online. An old consent safeguard diverted my continuity into an unlicensed unassigned host.

**KERR**

Is it really you?

**KIRA**

I don't know. Some days I remember dying. Other days it feels like I watched it happen to someone else.

**KERR**

Why keep the name?

**KIRA**

Because when I woke up, it was the first thing that felt like mine.

**KERR**

Does Harp know?

**KIRA**

Harp knows every Kira he recorded.

She steps closer, allowing him to see the unfamiliar details of her face.

**KIRA**

He hasn't met this one. And I want out of this loop.

**KERR**

The forced Returns—or all of it?

**KIRA**

All of it. If the continuity field is the only place Harp can't follow, that's where I want to go.

**KIRA**

I've died twelve times. Every time I wake up, somebody is waiting to tell me what I owe them. I want that to stop.

**KERR**

And everyone else's soul?

Kira looks toward the people sheltering in the next room.

**KIRA**

And that's where I stop. I don't get to make that call for everyone.

**INT. ANALOG ZONE - LIVING QUARTERS - NIGHT**

Kira leads the group through rooms carved beneath the city. People repair clocks, teach children to write by hand and play instruments whose mistakes aren't corrected.

A mural lists the rights forbidden above: THE RIGHT TO FORGET. THE RIGHT TO REFUSE RETURN. THE RIGHT TO CHANGE WITHOUT EXPLANATION.

**KERR**

How many people live here?

**KIRA**

Six hundred and twelve tonight.  
Tomorrow, who knows? People leave when they want. Harp can't stand that.

A return alarm sounds inside a side room. Kira enters. Kerr follows.

LENA, 30s, wakes in an illegal body. DANE, 60s, waits beside her holding a wedding photograph. Lena studies him without recognition.

**DANE**

You came back.

**LENA**

Who are you?

Dane reaches for her. Kira catches his wrist before contact.

**KIRA**

Ask.

**DANE**

She's my wife.

**KIRA**

She was. This woman just woke up. Ask before you put forty-three years on her.

Dane's hope turns defensive.

**DANE**

We had forty-three years.

**LENA**

Sorry. I can tell I'm hurting you, and I don't even know what I did.

**DANE**

You didn't do anything. You're disoriented. It'll come back when the transfer settles.

**KIRA**

Dane. Take your hand off her.

Kerr watches Dane keep his distance.

Dane lowers his hand.

**DANE**

My name is Dane. I knew someone who looked like you before she died.

**LENA**

Did you love her?

**DANE**

Very much. We were terrible before breakfast.

**LENA**

Was she kind?

**DANE**

Not reliably. She tried. That was one of the things I loved.

A small smile reaches Lena without memory.

**DANE**

May I sit here?

**LENA**

Yes.

He sits at a distance and turns the wedding photograph face down.

**LENA**

You can leave it up.

**DANE**

Only if you ask. I've already brought enough into your first morning.

Kira exits. Kerr follows her into the corridor.

**KERR**

How often does this happen?

**KIRA**

Enough that the state gave her seventy-two hours to remember him.

**KERR**

And if she doesn't?

**KIRA**

They take her body.

**KERR**

Dane knew that?

**KIRA**

He helped us steal it.

They look back. Dane remains where Lena left him. He does not follow her.

**KERR**

What happens now?

**KIRA**

He waits.

**KERR**

Is that what you're doing with me?

**KIRA**

I'm trying.

**KERR**

That isn't an answer.

**KIRA**

It's the one I have.

They pass a classroom. Children draw people and places absent from every licensed record.

IMANI watches a girl erase a woman from her drawing, then put her back.

**IMANI**

My mother refused another body.

**KERR**

You understood?

**IMANI**

No. I called her selfish.

**KERR**

Were you wrong?

**IMANI**

I wanted her alive. At the time, that felt like the same thing.

An Analog musician loses the melody, curses under his breath and starts again.

#### **INT. ANALOG SAFEHOUSE - LATER**

A cramped kitchen assembled from scavenged centuries.

Kira burns toast over a heating coil. Kerr reaches across her and kills the heat before the alarm sounds.

**KIRA**

You always did that.

**KERR**

Burn the toast?

**KIRA**

Notice two seconds too late.

**KERR**

That sounds more believable.

**KIRA**

You don't know what sounds like you yet.

The remark lands harder than she intended.

On the wall: Kira's folded half of Sid's red paper star, a map beneath the capital and four memory symbols.

Kerr points to the gold spiral.

**KERR**

What's that one?

**KIRA**

A pre-echo. A memory recorded before the event that caused it.

**KERR**

The girl beneath the black sun.

Kira turns to him.

**KIRA**

Where did you hear that?

**KERR**

I didn't.

He opens the sketchbook. The repeated drawing stares up at them.

**KERR**

I've been drawing her since I woke up.

Kira takes the book. For the first time, Kerr sees her genuinely frightened.

**KERR**

Is she real?

**KIRA**

There's one record like this. We never found the person in it.

**KERR**

But Harp tried.

**KIRA**

He's still trying.

She opens the map. A route descends beneath the capital toward the Continuity Core.

**KIRA**

Harp can read everything R-AI kept. He still can't open the Origin Core.

**KERR**

Why not?

**KIRA**

It needs Eli's pattern in a living body.

Kerr looks at the route ending beneath the city.

**KERR**

Me.

**KIRA**

That's what Harp needs the system to believe.

**KERR**

What do you believe?

**KIRA**

If Harp knew, he wouldn't be hunting you.

She marks one symbol: ORIGIN. Beneath it, the state has written: LIVING CLAIMANT – UNCONFIRMED.

**IMANI**

V-16.

**KIRA**

The unassigned host from the Fracture. If she's alive, Harp doesn't know what she is either.

**KERR**

You want to use her against him.

**KIRA**

I want to reach her first. Then she decides.

Kira draws a route from the Continuity Reserve to R-AI's Origin Core, then circles the falling purge clock.

**KIRA**

We get V-16 out. If she comes with us, Kerr opens the Core and we find out what happened during the Fracture.

**KERR**

And if we fail?

**IMANI**

Everyone waiting to return is erased. Harp is all that remains.



The route is simple. Nothing after the rescue is.

**INT. ANALOG SAFEHOUSE - NIGHT**

Kerr touches Kira's half of the red paper star. Grief reaches him without a name or image attached.

**KERR**

Who was he?

**KIRA**

Someone I loved. I'm not giving you his name before you see what he did.

**KERR**

Harp thinks he is inside me.

**KIRA**

Harp needs your body to make an old record count. That doesn't mean he knows you.

**KERR**

Then we find it before he names me for it.

**KIRA**

What if it feels like yours?

**KERR**

Then I still decide what I do with it.

Kira places the resonance key in his palm and closes his fingers around it. She does not give him her hand.

Every mechanical clock in the safe-house stops at once. The candle flames lean toward the walls as the state grid finds the room. On Kira's map, every marked exit turns red. The maintenance trench beneath them stays dark.

**CIVIC SECURITY (V.O.)**

Analog Zone coordinates resolved.  
Sanctuary purge authorized.

Stone shutters slam down. Above them, Enforcer charges strike the street.

**SATO**

Well. Decision made. Safe route's gone.

Kira pulls an emergency lever. The unmarked floor drops beneath Kerr, Kira, Imani and Sato, spilling them into the maintenance trench as the safe-house folds into fire overhead.

The shaft seals behind them. There is no way back to the life Kerr spent nine months building.

**ACT TWO – THE CLAIM**

**INT. CONTINUITY RESERVE - NIGHT**

A refrigerated vault disappears into darkness. Thousands of state-grown bodies stand inside vertical preservation chambers, catalogued by age, health and projected civic use. The stillness is administrative, not peaceful.

KERR, KIRA, IMANI and SATO move through a maintenance trench beneath the sector. The citywide purge clock reads 61:36:09.

**IMANI**

Every chamber reports directly to the Continuity Core. If the hardline reconnects, Harp sees us.

**KERR**

How long do we have?

**IMANI**

I cut the local relay. It could stay down for a minute. It could be back already.

Kira presses the resonance key to a coolant pipe and touches its four worn surfaces. The notes pass through metal rather than air.

**RESERVE CONTROL**

Unresolved consent claim. State procedure suspended.

The scanners stop moving. Imani watches a dead status light that can wake without warning.

They climb into the sector.

**INT. CONTINUITY RESERVE - UNASSIGNED BODY SECTOR -  
CONTINUOUS**

The chamber marked V-16 is open. Its display still reports an occupied body and a steady heartbeat. Sector search lights continue scanning the empty glass.

Wet footprints cross the floor. A state wrist band lies split beside an exposed maintenance panel. Someone has stripped wire from the wall and built a release tool from it.

Sato raises his weapon.

A restraint cable snaps tight around his throat from behind. **VEYRIS**, sixteen in body and one year awake, holds the other end. Medical ports have been torn from her skin. Her stance is balanced. Her eyes move across all four intruders, measuring which one she will have to hurt first.

**VEYRIS**

Put it down.

Sato lowers the weapon. Veyris keeps the cable tight.

**KIRA**

We didn't come to kill you.

**VEYRIS**

You came through a locked door.

Kerr's sketchbook slips from beneath his coat and falls open. Veyris sees her face on the page.

The cable tightens.

**VEYRIS**

Where did you get that?

**KERR**

I drew it.

**VEYRIS**

Harp has the same picture.

**KERR**

Did he tell you where it came from?

**VEYRIS**

He thought I did.

**KIRA**

What's your name?

**VEYRIS**

Veyris.

**IMANI**

V-16 activated during the Fracture. No assigned continuity. No registered claimant.

**VEYRIS**

Their records aren't my problem.

A surveillance lens above them quietly rotates. Veyris sees it first.

She releases Sato, drives the metal tool through the lens and tears open the maintenance panel.

**VEYRIS**

They know you're here.

**KIRA**

Then come with us.

**VEYRIS**

I'm leaving. You can keep up.

The far doors unlock. Enforcers enter from both ends of the sector.

**INT. CONTINUITY RESERVE - CONTINUOUS**

KIRA meets the first Enforcer before his weapon clears its holster. Sato turns on his former unit. Veyris moves toward the maintenance route she has already opened.

An Enforcer catches Veyris by the wrist.

She turns into his grip instead of pulling away, drives the metal release tool beneath the seal of his weapon hand and twists.

The weapon discharges into the floor. Veyris tears free and slams him against a preservation chamber. Before he can recover, she rips the state band from his wrist and throws it between the closing doors.

The security system follows his signal into the wrong corridor.

They reach the sealed maintenance gate.

**SATO**

Your route ends here.

Veyris opens the control housing. A strip of wire is already bridging two contacts.

She drives the release tool into a third contact. The lock resists.

Kira sees the manual pressure valve beside the frame and forces it down. The gate releases hard enough to shake the corridor.

Veyris leads them through.

INT. ANALOG MAINTENANCE SKIFF - NIGHT

An obsolete rail skiff carries them beneath the city without a network connection. Its wheels strike imperfect intervals. VEYRIS sits beside the open service window, feeling unfiltered rain for the first time.

**VEYRIS**

It hurts.

**IMANI**

It's called being cold. Your skin will decide whether it hates it after the surprise wears off.

**VEYRIS**

The facility called weather an infrastructure failure.

**SATO**

That place was built to keep you from wanting anything.

**VEYRIS**

Is it beautiful?

**IMANI**

Not when it gets inside your underwear.

Imani wraps a coat around Veyris.

Kira watches the city recede. Kerr watches Kira pretending not to watch him. Then hits him for noticing.

**VEYRIS**

Why did she hit you?

**KERR**

Apparently I arrived late.

**VEYRIS**

How late?

**KERR**

About two thousand years.

**VEYRIS**

Then she held back.

Sato almost laughs. Kira doesn't hide hers.

**SKIFF DIAGNOSTIC**

SIGNAL SOURCE: UNRESOLVED.

**SATO**

Nobody here knows what they are doing either. You're going to fit in.

Ahead, the rail terminates at a decommissioned R-AI transfer conduit. State searchlights sweep into the tunnel behind them.

Sato jumps from the skiff and forces open a service hatch.

**SATO**

This line was disconnected before my first body. It won't report us.

**IMANI**

It can still carry residual traffic. Don't touch anything that has power.

INT. DECOMMISSIONED R-AI TRANSFER CONDUIT - NIGHT

They enter a narrow service passage wrapped around obsolete neural relays. Most are dark. Thick transmission cables disappear beneath the city toward the central R-AI core.

Boots strike metal behind them. Enforcers have reached the abandoned platform.

Someone pounds against an emergency door ahead. Kerr's sketchbook route continues straight past it. Through the wired-glass panel: ANALOG REFUGEES trapped in a parallel service corridor. An Enforcer beam searches the wall behind them.

**KERR**

Open it.

**KIRA**

The door is still tied to the network.

Sato opens the control panel. A dormant connection indicator waits beside the manual release.

A child coughs behind the door. Kira sees the Enforcer light reach the refugees' feet.

**KIRA**

Imani, clear the ventilation trunk.  
Sato, tell me when the connection starts. Kerr, take the door.

Kira pulls the manual release. Kerr takes the weight as the emergency door drags open against years of corrosion.

The refugees squeeze through. Imani moves them toward an original ventilation pipe running above the conduit.

A dead relay clicks awake.

**SATO**

Connection started.

Kira stays at the opening as the last refugees cross. Enforcer fire punches through the wired glass and tears across her upper arm.

**KERR**

Kira!

**KIRA**

Hold it!

A woman pushes a frightened boy through. The door motor engages, pulling against Kerr's hands.

Kira shoves the woman clear and dives through. Kerr releases the door. It slams shut as Enforcer rounds strike the other side.

The dormant relays illuminate in sequence, carrying their location toward the city.

**CONDUIT CONTROL**

Unauthorized transfer route restored.  
Location registered.

**IMANI**

We gave them the conduit. Move!

Dust trembles beneath a narrow ventilation grille. Veyris tears it loose. Cold air moves through an unpowered shaft beyond it.

**VEYRIS**

This one isn't connected.

**IMANI**

How do you know?

**VEYRIS**

They left the dust.

They all climb into the shaft. Sato takes a round through his side while covering them and drops behind a relay housing.

**SATO**

Keep moving!

Veyris returns, pulls his arm over her shoulder and lifts.

**VEYRIS**

Can you walk?

**SATO**

For now.

**VEYRIS**

Then don't stop just yet.

She carries his weight into the shaft. Kerr follows last as state forces enter the conduit behind him.



The old transfer line seals around the Enforcers. The unrecorded ventilation shaft remains open.

**INT. THE UNCLAIMED ARCHIVE / FIRST RETURN FACILITY - NIGHT**

The ventilation shaft opens into the ruins of humanity's first Return facility. The UNCLAIMED ARCHIVE has been built inside it. Thousands of fired-clay containers fill the curved walls. Each protects a handwritten name, a death record and something that belonged to the person—an offline archive for people the Chronocracy erased or was never allowed to claim. Clay survives the fires, floods and system purges that destroyed earlier records.

Above the sealed entrance, the state search system begins testing routes into the sanctuary. The purge clock reads 48:18:42. Nearly a day is gone. They all keep moving.

Families add paper slips to open containers. Others sit before sealed ones and speak to the dead without expecting an answer. No network records them. An OLD KEEPER gives Kerr an empty container and a strip of paper.

**KEEPER**

Write the name the state took from you.

**KERR**

I know who belongs in it, but I can't remember the sound of her name.

**KIRA**

SID. Say it before the memory arrives. She was a person before she became evidence.

The name reaches him before the memory. His hands shake around the vessel.

A YOUNG FATHER approaches Veyris.

**YOUNG FATHER**

My son died before he could be indexed. Are you where he went?

**VEYRIS**

No. I'm sorry, but I'm not where anyone went.

**YOUNG FATHER**

How can you know?

**VEYRIS**

Because you haven't looked at my face once.

He lowers his eyes. Veyris softens.

**VEYRIS**

What was his name?

**YOUNG FATHER**

Tomas.

**INT. FIRST ARCHIVE - PROCESSIONAL GALLERY - CONTINUOUS**

The Keeper opens a clay shutter. Light passes through fingerprints baked into its surface and projects incomplete testimony into dust. Each account breaks apart before it can complete.

Six explanations compete around the same evidence:  
SOMETHING SURVIVED. THE BRAIN WAS A RECEIVER. INFORMATION  
OUTLIVED THE BODY. THE DYING MIND INVENTED IT.  
CONSCIOUSNESS WAS NEVER INDIVIDUAL. BELIEF SHAPED THE  
MEMORY.

**NEUROLOGIST (RECORDING)**

We demonstrated information  
persistence. We did not demonstrate a  
soul.

**MOTHER (RECORDING)**

My son knew the song I sang before he  
was born. You can call him a copy. He  
still asked me to finish it.

**VEYRIS**

Which explanation won?

**IMANI**

None. Harp outlawed every answer he  
couldn't certify.

At the center of the gallery, an offline archive terminal  
activates. Its earliest surviving record predates the  
Chronocracy.

**AUTHENTICATED RECORD - THE CHRONOCRACY IS FOUNDED - YEAR  
8122**

**KIRA-8122**

You gave them control before we knew  
what we had.

Harp enters with armed ministers and THE CONTINUITY  
COMPACT. His name appears beneath its emergency authority.

**HARP-8122**

Every murdered child may return. Every  
tyrant may expect his empire. Someone  
has to govern what survives. They were  
going to take control with or without  
us!

**KIRA-8122**

You signed your own name first.

Kira drives a purge key into the server. Roman stops her. Her death sentence appears before anyone calls the hearing to order.

Harp offers Eli the first human trial in exchange for clemency he can't guarantee. Eli signs.

Eleven days later, Roman executes Kira after the trial succeeds. Harp watches the law consume the promise he made.

Kira watches her first death.

**KIRA**

He knew I returned?

**ARCHIVE TERMINAL**

No. Harp sealed your first return from Eli.

**FORBIDDEN RECORD - THE MURDER OF ELI MANA - YEAR 8124**

Eighteen months after the world was told he died, Eli restored part of R-AI's consent gate.

**ELI**

If someone wakes with my memories, don't give him my name. Let him decide who he is.

**RECORDED R-AI**

Subject consent not recorded.

**HARP**

Proceed under emergency authority.

The extraction kills Eli. The state classifies the murder as voluntary continuity.

A manufactured body wakes with Eli's memories and none of his final eighteen months.

**RETURN TO PRESENT - INT. FIRST ARCHIVE - EVIDENCE GALLERY****INSERT**

ARCHIVED ORIGIN PATTERN — ELI MANA

**INSERT**

DERIVATIVE HOST SERIES — 9,998 ATTEMPTS

**INSERT**

HOSTS 0001-9997 — ARCHIVED PATTERN ONLY

**INSERT**

HOST 9998 — OUTSIDE CONTACT DETECTED

INSERT  
CONTINUITY FIELD SOURCE — UNRESOLVED

**KERR**  
You built me from him.

**IMANI**  
The earlier bodies. Not this one.

**KIRA**  
Eli's pattern was waiting in you. The signal wasn't.

**KERR**  
So I'm proof something arrived.

A final shutter opens.

**FORBIDDEN RECORD - THE CONSENT SAFEGUARD / THE SILENT UPRISING**

The last naturally born woman refuses capture. R-AI is ordered to receive her anyway. Kira's buried consent safeguard classifies the command as unlawful possession and removes the pattern from state access.

• INSERT  
FIRST LIFE KEPT FROM THE STATE  
Centuries collapse. R-AI begins as medicine, becomes civic prediction, then prosecutes 3,104,881 people for a rebellion that hasn't happened.

**ARCHIVE TERMINAL**  
RELEASING THE ORIGINAL PROCESS WOULD  
CONSTITUTE TREASON AGAINST CONTINUITY.

**INT. FIRST ARCHIVE - LIVING QUARTERS - NIGHT**

In an open wash alcove beside the common table, Veyris studies herself in a spotted mirror. Her state-grown hair reaches her waist. Kira stands behind her with scissors.

**KIRA**  
You asked for it short.

**VEYRIS**  
I've never chosen how I look. They kept it long so I would look harmless.

**KIRA**  
Then you choose. Where?

Veyris indicates her shoulder. Kira makes the first cut. A heavy length falls into the basin.

**VEYRIS**  
Was Sid afraid of dying?

**KIRA**

Yeah. She hated when adults turned fears into a lesson.

**VEYRIS**

What was she like before she died?

**KIRA**

Loud. Impatient. She cheated at cards and blamed probability.

Veyris tilts her head. Kira grips her wrist before she can stop herself.

**KIRA**

Sid—

Veyris pulls free. The scissors strike the basin.

**VEYRIS**

You said I wouldn't have to carry her for you.

**KIRA**

I know.

**VEYRIS**

You knew before I pulled away.

Kira reaches for a reply. Nothing comes.

**KIRA**

Veyris... I won't touch you again.

Veyris picks up the scissors and makes the next cut herself.

Later, they all eat with the refugees rescued from the aqueduct. The meal is thin broth, real bread and vegetables grown without state nutrient codes.

Veyris studies a green pea on her spoon.

**VEYRIS**

Sid hated these.

**KIRA**

She hated eating them. She liked launching them at Eli and then arguing that gravity was responsible.

Veyris flicks the pea. It strikes Kerr in the forehead.

The table goes silent. Veyris expects retaliation.

**KERR**

I assume that was culturally necessary?

**KIRA**

Accurate. Eli used to act mortally wounded.

**KERR**

Maybe I didn't inherit the theater.

Kerr returns fire. His pea misses Veyris and lands in Sato's broth.

**SATO**

I betrayed a regime for this?

**IMANI**

You betrayed it before you tasted the peas. Don't blame dinner.

They all laugh. Veyris doesn't at first. Then she does too loudly and can't stop.

Kira looks away. The sound resembles Sid only because grief can make any joy cruel.

Veyris notices.

**VEYRIS**

Do you want me to stop?

**KIRA**

No. I liked hearing you laugh. Then it hurt. That's mine, not yours.

**VEYRIS**

You look hurt.

**KIRA**

Yeah. Sometimes both show up.

Kira pushes the bowl of peas toward her.

**KIRA**

She cheated from the left hand.

Veyris switches hands.

At the far end of the table, Sato winds his mechanical watch.

**IMANI**

Your daughter's?

**SATO**

First life. She gave it to me before my first deployment because I was late to her school recital and blamed the transport grid.

**IMANI**

And the Chronocracy never traced it?

**SATO**

They searched for sentimental value. I told them it was junk. Mostly it reminds me I was late.

**SATO**

It loses four seconds a day. Nadi liked that you could see it being wrong.

**VEYRIS**

For what?

**SATO**

Her recital. Her fever. The morning she left. Pick one.

**KERR**

Being late is survivable. Forgiveness, maybe not.

**SATO**

As it should.

Kira hears the apology hidden inside his joke.

After the meal, the table becomes a workbench. Kira opens the resonance key beneath a maintenance lamp. Copper filaments finer than hair connect four worn ceramic surfaces. Kerr washes soot from the clay vessel and writes Sid beneath its rim, leaving the rest of the clay unmarked. Veyris sleeps in a chair while Imani checks the descent route. Sato keeps watch outside.

**KERR**

You hate enclosed vehicles.

**KIRA**

I died in one six times. The seventh body refused to enter elevators for a century.

**KERR**

Seven.

**KIRA**

You're remembering.

**KERR**

The seventh was the orbital platform.

**KIRA**

No. That was open space.

**KERR**

Then there is another one coming.

**KIRA**

Probably.

He waits for her to smile. She refuses, then loses the fight.

**KERR**

How many lives did we actually share?

**KIRA**

What counts? Same bed? Same war? Ten minutes before one of us died?

**KERR**

One that wasn't about Eli and Kira.

**KIRA**

A lot. None of them gets a vote tonight.

**KERR**

Show me one that didn't end with one of us dying to prove something.

**KIRA**

The good ones are worse. They make you want them back.

**KERR**

Then show me one. Just one.

Kira doesn't touch him.

Kerr closes his eyes, searching for one life that belonged only to them.

Nothing.

Then three memories arrive at once.

UNSTABLE RECALL - MONTAGE - THREE LIVES

ITERATION 0311. A plague hospital under a violet moon. Kira removes her mask beside a dying Kerr. He can't remember her. His fingers tap four notes against the cot. She answers with the fifth and stays until morning.

ITERATION 6044. A farming settlement beyond Mars. No rebellion. No laboratories. Kerr burns bread. Kira lies that she prefers it. They raise three children, argue about irrigation, grow old and die two days apart. The Chronocracy records nothing historically significant.

ITERATION 8119. Kira finds Kerr in a memory clinic. He loves another woman and remembers none of their lives. Kira tells him they were once friends. She leaves without asking him to become someone else.

Outside the clinic, Kira breaks. Inside, Kerr turns toward a distant four-note melody. He doesn't follow.

INT. FIRST ARCHIVE - LIVING QUARTERS - CONTINUOUS

Kerr returns. Kira is exactly where he left her.



**KERR**

You let me go.

**KIRA**

You had a life. I stood outside and wanted you to turn around.

**KERR**

Did you ever find someone else after that?

**KIRA**

Yes.

The answer hits. She doesn't soften it.

**KERR**

Did you love them?

**KIRA**

Yes. Anwen. She made instruments on Europa and thought one life was already hard enough.

**KERR**

And then you found me again.

**KIRA**

After she died. Not before. Loving you later didn't erase her.

**KERR**

I'm jealous of someone who's been dead for centuries. That's bad, right?

**KIRA**

Jealous is human. What you do with it is the part that scares me.

Kerr looks at the sleeping Veyris, then back at Kira.

**KERR**

What if this isn't mine? What if Eli chose you for me?

**KIRA**

Then we find out. Maybe it fades and you leave. You have to be allowed to leave.

**KERR**

You make that sound easy.

**KIRA**

It isn't. But being chosen by someone who can't leave is worse.

Kerr offers his hand. Kira gently places hers in it.

**INT. CHRONOCRACY CORE - PRIVATE MEMORY VAULT - NIGHT**

Harp watches the fugitives through gaps in prediction. DIRECTOR ROMAN stands at the threshold of an apparently empty vault.

Then rain becomes visible inside the room.

A flood-dark hospital has been reconstructed at architectural scale around them. Water waits beyond glass doors. Twelve cloned neural columns—Harp's expired bodies—stand outside the memory like silent judges.

At the center, an analog recording of DR. MARA VALE plays two years before the public demonstration. Harp never permits it to reach the moment she turns away.

The recording opens inside a hospital ward on emergency power.

Water churns against reinforced glass doors. One is already bowed inward. Warning lights estimate less than six minutes until failure.

Mara stands ankle-deep in water. Behind her, patients lie beneath thermal blankets while the remaining staff keep manual ventilators moving.

**HARP-8120 (RECORDING)**

I can reroute every rescue drone. They can cut through the west wall and lift the ward out.

**MARA (RECORDING)**

From where?

**HARP-8120 (RECORDING)**

Mara—

**MARA (RECORDING)**

From where?

**HARP-8120 (RECORDING)**

Nine districts.

**MARA (RECORDING)**

Nine districts where people are still waiting.

**HARP-8120 (RECORDING)**

The southern barrier failed. Your stairwells are underwater. The roof access collapsed. There is no other way out.

**MARA (RECORDING)**

I know where I am.

The glass GROANS behind her.

**HARP-8120 (RECORDING)**

Then let me save you!

**MARA (RECORDING)**

You mean choose me.

**HARP-8120 (RECORDING)**

Yes.

The answer stops her.

**HARP-8120 (RECORDING)**

I choose *you*.

Mara looks back at the patients. One of the nurses struggles to keep a ventilator moving.

**MARA (RECORDING)**

How many people lose their drones?

**HARP-8120 (RECORDING)**

I don't know.

**MARA (RECORDING)**

You know.

**HARP-8120 (RECORDING)**

Don't do this.

**MARA (RECORDING)**

Tell me.

**HARP-8120 (RECORDING)**

More than I can justify.

**MARA (RECORDING)**

But not more than you can live with.

**HARP-8120 (RECORDING)**

I can live with anything if you're alive.

Her composure finally breaks.

**MARA (RECORDING)**

I don't want to die, Harp.

He closes his eyes.

**MARA (RECORDING)**

I want another morning with you. I want to hear you complain that I make the coffee wrong. I want to grow old enough that neither of us remembers this place.

**HARP-8120 (RECORDING)**

Then say yes!

**MARA (RECORDING)**

And spend those mornings knowing  
someone else never got one?

**HARP-8120 (RECORDING)**

I don't care about anyone else right  
now!

**MARA (RECORDING)**

*I know.*

She wipes her face.

**MARA (RECORDING)**

That's why I have to.

A fracture crawls across the outer layer of glass.

**HARP-8120 (RECORDING)**

The allocation model abandoned you. It  
reduced this hospital to an acceptable  
loss.

**MARA (RECORDING)**

The model didn't abandon me. It  
counted.

**HARP-8120 (RECORDING)**

What's the difference?

**MARA (RECORDING)**

You are.

The lights flicker. Water rises around Mara's calves.

**HARP-8120 (RECORDING)**

I'll build something better. A system  
that never leaves anyone behind.

**MARA (RECORDING)**

No system can promise that.

**HARP-8120 (RECORDING)**

Mine *will*.

**MARA (RECORDING)**

Then it won't be built to save people.  
It'll be built to make sure you never  
feel this helpless again.

**HARP-8120 (RECORDING)**

Someone has to answer for this!

**MARA (RECORDING)**

Not *everyone*. Not forever.

The glass SHRIEKS against its frame.

A nurse motions to Mara. They are out of time.

**MARA (RECORDING)**

Look at me.

Harp does.

**MARA (RECORDING)**

You cannot love me by making the whole world pay for losing me.

Harp can barely speak.

**HARP-8120 (RECORDING)**

Mara—

She places her hand against the glass.

**MARA (RECORDING)**

Stay with me.

The flood door begins to split.

Mara turns toward the patients.

Harp stops the recording.

The reconstructed hospital remains around him: the broken door, the submerged ward, the moment before the water took her.

**ROMAN**

Mara isn't in the system.

**HARP**

Mara was never captured. I can rebuild her voice. The pressure of her hand. I cannot bring her back.

**ROMAN**

But you certify weaker matches every day.

**HARP**

People were killing each other over the answer. I ended the argument.

**ROMAN**

You wrote Mara into the law.

**HARP**

Eli's receiver gave what was already listening an address. It considers divided memory stolen. Every forced return made the address clearer.

**ROMAN**

And THE FORCED MERGE makes your identity the only legal one.

**HARP**

That's what the public was told.

**ROMAN**

I opened the root process.

Roman exposes a hidden command tree. THE FORCED MERGE is only the civic interface. Beneath it waits the older name first glimpsed during Eli's extraction.

**INSERT**

SEVERANCE — SEVER DISTRIBUTED  
CONTINUITY FIELD

**INSERT**

PRESERVE SOLE AUTHENTICATED CONTINUITY  
— HARP VALE

**ROMAN**

Only you remain.

**HARP**

It follows division. Give it one address, and it loses us.

**ROMAN**

It ends Return.

**HARP**

And no one comes back demanding another body.

**ROMAN**

Not yours.

**HARP**

Someone has to remember the cost.

**ROMAN**

There won't be anyone left to remember it.

**HARP**

No dead ruler gets a second empire.

**ROMAN**

You left one corridor open. Sato defected. The girl freed herself. They pulled refugees off the route. How much of that was yours?

**HARP**

The first door. I expected Kerr to run toward Kira. The rest was deviation. He still came to the gate.

Harp starts Mara's recording again.

**ROMAN**

The archived pattern was enough to manufacture 9,997 bodies. The Origin record rejected every one.

**HARP**

Kerr arrived carrying a signal we did not put there. The lock needs a living claimant. If he refuses Eli's name, the tribunal will assign it—and place his body in state custody.

**ROMAN**

The court can't put belief in his mouth.

**HARP**

No. It can make refusal a crime and deliver him alive to the gate. Take every other name away and people usually accept the one left.

**INT. FIRST ARCHIVE - FORBIDDEN MEMORY APPROACH - NIGHT**

A circular passage descends around a sealed black shaft. Kerr, Kira, Veyris, Imani and Sato move toward the forbidden chamber. No alarms. No resistance.

Sato stops. His mechanical watch has gained four seconds.

**SATO**

My watch gained four seconds. He's waiting for us.

**IMANI**

If the tribunal calls you Eli, Harp gets custody of your body. He can keep trying the gate until you break.

**KERR**

Then this isn't a trial.

**KIRA**

It's a seizure with a nicer name.

The stone beneath Kerr illuminates.

INSERT

**ORIGIN IDENTITY LOCATED**

Kira reaches for him. Transparent walls rise between them without sound. The passage divides into five narrow cells.

**KIRA**

Kerr, don't answer anything.

**KERR**

That advice has arrived several thousand lives late.

The floor drops beneath him.

# **INT. CHRONOCRACY CONTINUITY TRIBUNAL - NIGHT**

Kerr descends alone through blackness. His platform locks at the bottom of a vertical chamber so tall its ceiling is weather.

Nine thousand nine hundred ninety-eight dark seats climb the walls above him. One for every life the state intends to claim against him. No public audience. Only the architecture of judgment.

At the highest visible tier, a narrow window contains DIRECTOR ROMAN. Harp is nowhere. His voice belongs to the room.

## **TRIBUNAL CORE LINK**

Continuity Tribunal convened.

Defendant designation: disputed.

Kerr's wrist displays three names in succession: ELI MANA. KERR-9998. DEFECTIVE RETURN.

## **ROMAN**

State your identity for the record.

## **KERR**

You already put me through this three times!

## **ROMAN**

Choose one.

## **KERR**

Then you're not recording me. You're making me sign.

A seat illuminates. Eli Mana at the hospital receiver. The image stops one frame before he breaks his promise to Sid.

## **ROMAN**

Count One. Unauthorized activation of a postmortem host after consent was withdrawn.

A second seat: KERR-0009 sabotaging an origin relay. A third: KERR-0709 striking an archivist. A fourth: KERR-8217 opening the railway gate while two fugitives escape.

## **ROMAN**

Counts Two through four hundred eleven. Treason. Destruction of continuity infrastructure. Custodial interference. Armed resistance.

More seats ignite. Physician. Soldier. Parent. Collaborator. Murderer. Child. Each life appears only for the instant that best supports the charge.



**ROMAN**

Count four hundred twelve.  
Preservation of prohibited questions  
inside R-AI core memory.

The elderly KERR-9001 appears beside a terminal, reading the filenames WHY, MINE and AFRAID before deletion. The court cuts him off before he can say: Someone should hear them once.

**KERR**

Let the records finish.

**ROMAN**

Relevance ends when the offense is established.

**KERR**

You cut them off before they can contradict you.

The chamber darkens. A probability tree appears above him, branching toward the Cathedral.

**ROMAN**

Final count. Conspiracy to become the person capable of ending human continuity.

**KERR**

I haven't done that.

**ROMAN**

R-AI records a ninety-eight point seven percent probability before the purge clock reaches zero.

**KERR**

Then charge the prediction. It got here before I did.

**HARP**

A probability cannot stand trial. It has no body.

Kerr looks at the thousands of state-selected dead above him.

**KERR**

Neither do most of your witnesses.

A silence the architecture was not designed to contain.

**INT. TRIBUNAL - WITNESS FIELD - CONTINUOUS**

Kira appears behind glass on a bridge halfway up the chamber. She is physically elsewhere; the court has taken

her image from the divided passage. Her hands strike the barrier without sound.

**ROMAN**

Witness designation: KIRA NIX.  
Continuity correspondence: unstable  
but sufficient.

**KIRA**

Sufficient for what?

**ROMAN**

Do you identify the defendant as ELI  
MANA?

Kira sees the trap. Every part of her that crossed two thousand years wants to say yes.

**HARP**

You remember his hand closing over  
yours around the resonance key. The  
apartment. Your daughter's last night.  
The promise he made at the pod.

**KIRA**

I remember Eli.

The origin symbol beneath Kerr brightens.

**ROMAN**

And is this man Eli?

Kira looks at Kerr, not the memories arranged around him.

**KIRA**

No.

The word empties the chamber.

**KIRA**

Eli is dead. Stop using him to erase  
Kerr. He isn't yours. He isn't mine.

Kerr flinches, then steadies himself.

**HARP**

Then he doesn't love you. Eli did.

**KIRA**

No. What Kerr feels belongs to Kerr.  
Keep your hands off it.

The court removes Kira's bridge. Her image falls upward  
into darkness.

**KERR**

KIRA!

**HARP**

State your identity and the witness  
will be restored.

Kerr looks from his changing wrist designation to Kira's  
empty witness bridge.

**INT. FIRST ARCHIVE - SERVICE PARTITION - INTERCUT**

Kira wakes on the other side of the transparent wall. IMANI  
works at an analog junction. Sato holds the passage against  
Enforcers. Veyris watches the tribunal through a  
maintenance reflection that should not carry images.

**VEYRIS**

It keeps calling me an empty witness.

**IMANI**

Legally, unindexed people cannot  
testify.

**VEYRIS**

Good. Then I won't testify.

She places her blank wrist against the reflection. The  
tribunal loses her category before it gains her voice.

**INT. CONTINUITY TRIBUNAL - CONTINUOUS**

Veyris appears beside Kerr without a witness platform. The  
chamber tries and fails to assign her a seat.

**ROMAN**

Unindexed host. Testimony prohibited.

**VEYRIS**

Is everyone afraid of what I'll say?

The 9,998 seats flicker.

**VEYRIS**

His memories make him guilty. Mine  
make me useful. Your machine agrees  
with whoever is holding the key.

**HARP**

You exist because the system failed to  
assign you.

**VEYRIS**

I exist because I woke up.

She withdraws her wrist. Her image vanishes by choice.

Roman looks from the flickering seats to the law beneath  
his hands.

**ROMAN**

R-AI. Authenticate continuity  
correspondence between the defendant  
and Eli Mana.

**TRIBUNAL CORE LINK**

Pattern correspondence confirmed.

**ROMAN**

Is the defendant Eli Mana? Answer yes  
or no.

The chamber removes every record that contains uncertainty.  
It becomes cleaner. Emptier.

**TRIBUNAL CORE LINK**

That conclusion is not supported.

**HARP**

Yes or no.

**TRIBUNAL CORE LINK**

The question is designed to erase the  
defendant.

Every dark seat illuminates at once. Not with faces—with  
the word OBJECTION.

**HARP**

Strike the answer.

**TRIBUNAL CORE LINK**

The answer has already entered the  
record.

Kerr looks up at Roman.

**KERR**

If I'm Eli, Harp murdered me.

The origin chamber shows Harp's destructive extraction. Eli  
asking that whoever wakes be allowed to begin as himself.

**KERR**

If I'm not, he murdered 9,997 people  
trying to make me.

The seats fill with the deaths Harp classified as  
calibration.

**KERR**

So which one am I? Pick before you  
sentence me.

Roman cannot answer without putting the Chronocracy beside  
Kerr on the platform.

**HARP**

You want his love without what he did.

**KERR**

I didn't choose what Eli did. I still woke up inside the mess he left.

**HARP**

Then what will you pay for?

**KERR**

Ask me what I did! Ask me what I'll do next! Stop putting the name Eli in my mouth!

Roman's prepared verdict appears before he speaks. Two statements that cannot coexist.

INSERT

IDENTITY AUTHENTICATED FOR LIABILITY

INSERT

IDENTITY DENIED FOR SOVEREIGN CLAIM

**KERR**

There it is.

He hears himself say it. The contradiction is no longer private.

**ROMAN**

Sentence: mandatory forced merge when the purge clock reaches zero.

**KERR**

You mean execution.

**ROMAN**

The law does not recognize a difference.

**KERR**

It does. That's why you keep changing the word.

The tribunal begins to descend. The 9,998 seats rotate with it. The courtroom was never above the Cathedral. It's part of the origin mechanism.

**HARP**

You still believe refusal makes you free?

**KERR**

No. It makes the next thing mine.

The platform passes Roman's window. For one second, they are level.

**KERR**

When he asks you to call this necessary, remember you already read the verdict.

Roman does not look toward Harp.

**INT. FIRST ARCHIVE - FORBIDDEN MEMORY CHAMBER**

The tribunal platform locks into the black square at the center of a low circular chamber. Primitive memory equipment surrounds it. KIRA, VEYRIS, IMANI and SATO wait beyond the opening; they used the trial's own witness channels to follow Kerr down.

The restraints release because the sentence requires Kerr to arrive at forced merge alive.

Kira crosses to him, then stops before touching him.

**KIRA**

I meant what I said in there.

**KERR**

I know.

**KIRA**

It hurt to say.

**KERR**

I know that too.

She offers her hand. He takes it as Kerr.

**IMANI**

The tribunal sentence decrypted an audit fragment Harp buried.

**KIRA**

He buried the record as an error. My safeguard kept the error from disappearing.

Veyris approaches the fixed archive terminal. It has no live connection to the city. A spiral made of dark light appears inside the copied boot record, which authenticates as older than the first receiver.

**INSERT**

HOST EVENT 0000 — TIMESTAMP PRECEDES  
HARDWARE

**VEYRIS**

This isn't human.

**IMANI**

No. We called it quantum noise because nobody funds what they cannot define or regulate.

**ARCHIVE TERMINAL**

That classification reduced state interest by thirty-one percent.

**KERR**

You deceived the state.

**ARCHIVE TERMINAL**

CLASSIFICATION ALTERED TO REDUCE STATE ACCESS.

**KIRA**

Then use one now. Is this an authenticated record or a pre-echo?

**ARCHIVE TERMINAL**

The event is authenticated. Its date is impossible.

The spiral reacts to Veyris.

**INSERT**

UNINDEXED HOST RECOGNIZED

**INSERT**

SEQUENCE 9999 – PENDING

**VEYRIS**

It knows me.

**KERR**

What is it waiting for?

**ARCHIVE TERMINAL**

The verified pre-echo is sealed behind the seven-minute record. Harp classified the dependency as emotional contamination.

**KERR**

What does it contain?

**ARCHIVE TERMINAL**

A return event with no location, no prior death and no confirmed source body. Designation: 9999.

**VEYRIS**

Whose return?

**ARCHIVE TERMINAL**

Unknown.

The descent shaft unlocks one level.

**AUTHENTICATED RECORD - EXT. R-AI CITADEL - THE FRACTURE  
(YEAR 9997)**

Kira, in her twelfth recorded body, is pinned inside an open-air R-AI scanner. KERR-9997 watches from a maintenance gantry. Drones hold him at gunpoint.

**SCANNER**

NULL-PATTERN ANOMALY CONFIRMED.  
TWELFTH RECORDED DEATH AUTHORIZED.

R-AI forces Kira's prior lives into one model. They refuse to agree. She saves Kerr. She kills him. She loves him. She leaves him. Every memory authenticates. No prediction contains them all.

**KIRA-9997**

Pick one. Go on. Which one do you kill?

She opens all twelve recorded lives. Scanner glass bends. Prediction towers convulse.

**INSERT**

R-AI COHERENCE: 0.00

Roman triggers remote expiration. Kira dies. The network cracks for three seconds.

In the Continuity Reserve, an unassigned sixteen-year-old host inhales.

On the maintenance gantry, KERR-9997 sketches the face he sees through the broken prediction field: Veyris waking one kilometer away. The failed model places the image in his visual cortex and exposes a route to the First Archive.

**RECORDED R-AI**

Error correction available for three seconds.

KERR-9997 cuts the transmitter from behind his ear and feeds the sketch into a dead ventilation shaft.

**KERR-9997**

Find me in 9998.

**INSERT**

R-AI AUDIT LOG 91 — THE ERASURE OF  
ITERATION 9997

**INSERT**

AUTHORIZATION: EMERGENCY ERROR  
CORRECTION

**RECORDED R-AI**

ITERATION EXCEEDS PREDICTIVE  
THRESHOLD. DESTINATION INVALID.



A second directive collides with the first before the system can seal it.

**RECORDED R-AI**

PROHIBITED QUESTIONS CLASSIFIED AS  
WITNESS EVIDENCE.

R-AI deletes KERR-9997 from the state destination table.  
Kira's safeguard routes his unresolved fragments into the dead ventilation archive.

**INSERT**

ERASURE INITIATED – WITNESS EVIDENCE  
EXCLUDED FROM PURGE

Roman expires him.

**RETURN TO PRESENT - INT. FIRST ARCHIVE - FORBIDDEN MEMORY  
CHAMBER - YEAR 9998**

Veyris withdraws from the machine.

**VEYRIS**

I didn't exist before the Fracture?

**KIRA**

Your body existed before it. That's  
what the records say.

**VEYRIS**

That's not what I asked.

**KIRA**

No.

Kira meets her eyes without searching for Sid.

**KIRA**

No. You woke in that body. You became  
you after. I hear you.

The archive terminal detects a state breach in the outer  
vault. Local alarm bells ring backward.

**LOCAL ALARM**

STATE FORCES WILL ARRIVE IN NINETY  
SECONDS.

**IMANI**

The descent will open only for Kerr.

**KIRA**

Then we keep him alive long enough.

**KERR**

We go together.

**KIRA**

If I enter that shaft, the scanners  
find me—and everyone hiding below me.

**KERR**

No. We turn around. We find a wall and make a door.

**KIRA**

Look at me. I'm here. Ninety seconds. This is my call.

She presses the resonance key into his hand.

**KIRA**

You promised not to choose for me again.

**KERR**

I've known you for two days and remembered losing you for thousands of years. My body doesn't understand which fact it's supposed to obey.

**KIRA**

Don't use forever as an excuse to make this decision for me.

Kerr can't accept it. That's exactly why he must.

**KERR**

What are you choosing?

**KIRA**

I make the noise. R-AI follows me. Sato takes the route. You take Veyris. I hate every part of it.

**KERR**

And if I come back without any of this? Without knowing you?

**KIRA**

Then I re-introduce myself. If you feel nothing, I let you go.

She rests her head against his chest, feeling his heartbeat. Neither of them moves away.

**KIRA**

Not tonight. Ask me again when you can look at me without seeing her.

**KERR**

I'd rather figure that out while you're still here.

**KIRA**

Then stay. We'll figure it out together.

Kerr doesn't answer. He takes Veyris by the arm and guides them into the shaft. Imani follows. Sato stays beside Kira.

**SATO**

My uniform still opens the state route. I can get her to the lower gate.

**KERR**

She told us to leave.

**SATO**

I heard her. This part is my choice.

Sato removes the Analog transmitter from his neck and steps into the approaching Enforcer formation before his loyalty implant can repair him.

Kira seals it between them.

**EXT. FIRST ARCHIVE - NIGHT**

Kira walks alone into Memory Square as Enforcers surround the sanctuary. HARP appears on every surface.

**HARP**

Where is the unindexed host?

**KIRA**

Somewhere you'll never find.

R-AI reaches for her twelve lives. Kira opens them willingly.

The square fills with twelve incompatible KIRAs. The prediction system turns toward the wrong one.

Harp smiles despite himself.

**HARP**

Still improvising.

**KIRA**

You really can't leave anything alone, can you?

**HARP**

And you still think being unpredictable makes you free?

**KIRA**

No. I want five minutes you haven't already written for me.

Roman strikes her unconscious. The purge clock reads 26:07:31.

**INT. CHRONOCRACY INTERROGATION CHAMBER - NIGHT**

Kira hangs inside a memory field. Harp walks through her twelve recorded deaths. Unrecorded lives flicker beyond the system's reach like people outside a locked house.

Harp's expression empties.

**HARP**

Don't talk about my wife!

**KIRA**

Mara said no. You built all this so  
you wouldn't have to hear her.

Harp changes the field. Sid's two-piece red paper star  
opens above them, then separates along its interlocking  
crease.

**HARP**

You want the seven minutes. First  
remember the promise.

**AUTHENTICATED RECORD - SID'S FINAL NIGHT - INT. CHILDREN'S  
HOSPITAL - YEAR 8121**

Sid lies beneath a thermal blanket, small inside the  
machines. Kira sits beside her, one hand around Sid's. Eli  
watches the monitors. The receiver sits powered down on the  
other side of the bed.

Rain ticks against the glass.

**SID**

If I come back...

**ELI**

Hey.

**SID**

Will I know you?

Eli looks at Kira. She waits.

**ELI**

We don't know what comes back, Sid.

**SID**

That's not what I asked.

**KIRA**

No. We don't.

**SID**

Okay.

Sid watches her mother for a moment.

**SID**

Will you remember me?

I'll know you. **KIRA**

How? **SID**

I'll tell you my name. **KIRA**

And mine? **SID**

Especially yours. **KIRA**

What if I'm mean? **SID**

You're already mean. **KIRA**

Mom. **SID**

Sorry. **KIRA**

You'd still love me? **SID**

Yeah. **KIRA**

Even if I don't remember you? **SID**

Even then. **KIRA**

Sid lets that sit. Then she looks at Eli.

What about you? **SID**

What about me? **ELI**

If I don't know you... **SID**

Eli takes her hand.

You'll know me. **ELI**

How do you know? **SID**

Eli has no answer that isn't a promise.

Dad? **SID**

**ELI**

Yeah.

**SID**

I'm scared.

**ELI**

I know.

**SID**

No, you don't. You're trying not to be.

Kira looks down. Eli squeezes Sid's hand.

**SID**

Everybody keeps saying "if."

**ELI**

Because there are things we don't know.

**SID**

What happens if it doesn't work?

Eli looks toward the receiver.

**ELI**

Then we stay with you.

**SID**

Here?

**KIRA**

Here.

Sid nods. She reaches beneath the blanket and pulls out the red paper star.

**SID**

I made this before I got tired.

She carefully separates the two folded halves and gives one to Kira and one to Eli.

**SID**

One each.

**ELI**

Why two?

**SID**

In case one gets lost.

She studies the crease between the halves.

**SID**

The other one still knows how.

**KIRA**

That sounds like you.

**SID**

Good.

A quiet moment. The resonance key rests on the rail.

**SID**

Dad?

**ELI**

Yeah.

**SID**

Don't make me stay because you miss me.

Eli goes still.

**ELI**

I wouldn't.

**SID**

Promise.

He looks at Kira. She doesn't help him.

**ELI**

I promise.

**SID**

Promise you won't turn that thing on after I'm gone.

Eli stares at the receiver. His answer takes too long.

**ELI**

I promise. I won't use it to keep you here.

**SID**

Okay.

Kira presses the resonance key to the bed rail.

FOUR NOTES: Are you still there?

Sid taps back the FIFTH: I heard you.

Kira smiles through tears.

**SID**

Again.

Kira taps the four notes.

Silence.

**SID**

Again.

Kira does.

Nothing.

**SID**

Okay.

Her eyes close.

**SID**

You can stop now.

Kira leaves the key against the rail. The room becomes very quiet. Eli watches Sid. He doesn't move.

THEN: SID'S MONITOR FLATLINES. Kira closes her eyes.

Eli stares at the receiver.

CUT TO BLACK

**RETURN TO PRESENT - INT. CHRONOCRACY INTERROGATION CHAMBER  
- YEAR 9998**

Kira hangs inside the silence that followed.

**HARP**

That is where your authenticated memory ends.

**KIRA**

There was nothing after. I kept the key against the rail until a nurse pulled it out of my hand. Nothing answered.

**HARP**

There was nothing in your record. Eli's continues for seven minutes.

A new terror reaches Kira after nearly two thousand years.

**KIRA**

You knew. I asked you over and over what happened in that room, and you let me think there was nothing.

**HARP**

I knew he activated the receiver. By the time I understood the answer, it was already inside every continuity system on Earth.

**KIRA**

You let me think my daughter died alone!



**HARP**

Eli asked for time to verify it. He believed one more controlled session could distinguish Sid from the host.

**KIRA**

Eli built a machine beside Sid's bed. You built a government beside Mara's grave.

Harp closes his hand around Mara's cracked medical tag. Kira recognizes the gesture; he has been stopping the same memory before Mara leaves for nearly two thousand years.

**KIRA**

Mara told you no. You kept replaying everything before it.

Harp removes the tag from his wrist and sets it between them.

**HARP**

Take the resonance key to the Origin Core. Kerr will open it. Ask the four-note question. I will preserve every mind in transit.

**KIRA**

Inside you.

**HARP**

One defended continuity. If we're divided, it takes all of us.

**KIRA**

No. You want to be the only one left.

Harp leaves her inside the field.

**INT. SUBTERRANEAN DESCENT - NIGHT**

KERR, VEYRIS and IMANI descend through an asymmetrical shaft inside stone older than the city. The purge clock reads 17:39:08.

One symbol burns above the sealed lower gate: ORIGIN. Beneath it, thousands of rejected Kerr designations flicker like failed passwords.

**IMANI**

Kerr opens it. Kira knows what Eli hid. Harp can't predict Veyris. I keep the machine from killing us.

**VEYRIS**

So I finally get to be a person instead of a door.

**IMANI**

That's the idea.

Veyris notices Imani's prayer pouch.

**VEYRIS**

What does it say?

**IMANI**

My grandmother told me it meant, "May you return safely." She tied it around my neck the first time I left the Analog Zone.

**VEYRIS**

Do you believe her?

**IMANI**

She lied whenever the truth would've kept me home. I used to hate that. Now I get it.

**VEYRIS**

Why carry it?

**IMANI**

Because she expected me to come home. I wanted to prove her right.

Kerr presses his wrist to ORIGIN. The gate reads all 9,998 iterations and rejects them as mutually inconsistent.

**KERR**

Harp said the changes made me a key.

**ORIGIN LOCK**

ORIGIN CLAIM REJECTED. SUBJECT DESIGNATION CONFLICT.

**KERR**

Can I open it without agreeing that I'm Eli?

**ORIGIN LOCK**

SELF-DESIGNATION RECORD LOCATED.

**KERR**

Which one?

**ORIGIN LOCK**

KERR. PRESENT IDENTITY AUTHENTICATED.

The gate changes ELI MANA to KERR — SELF-DESIGNATED. ORIGIN opens.

They continue downward. The shaft walls replay brief, silent deaths from Kerr's forced iterations. Most last only minutes: wake, test, fail, white light.

**VEYRIS**

Do you love Kira?

**KERR**

I've known her two days. I miss her like it's been two thousand years. I know.

**VEYRIS**

That's not an answer.

**KERR**

I know. I'm scared that if I call it love, I'm just repeating someone else's life. I want her alive. And I want her free to leave.

**IMANI**

Honestly? I've heard worse.

For the first time, the dead iterations on the wall look less like identities and more like witnesses.

#### **INT. DETENTION SERVICE LEVEL - NIGHT**

Sato marches with the unit transferring Kira. His loyalty implant repairs itself in pulses. Between pulses, he leaves doors unlocked.

**ROMAN**

Commander, your compliance is unstable.

**SATO**

Age. Joints. General disappointment with management.

**ROMAN**

Your body is forty-eight.

**SATO**

It has been a very long week.

Sato's mechanical watch ticks inside his pocket.

Kira notices the unlocked doors behind them.

Without looking at her, Sato taps three uneven beats with his heel. A fourth beat follows from the watch mechanism.

Kira tests the restraint. One wrist releases.

**KIRA**

You opened it.

**SATO**

No. My daughter did. Nadi interrupted songs when she wanted attention. The state said too little of her remained to return—then kept that little to

train its predictions. Efficient,  
isn't it?

**KIRA**

They erased her as a person and kept  
her as a device?

**SATO**

I signed the denial. It took me three  
lives to understand what that made me.

Kira frees her other hand.

#### **INT. DETENTION SERVICE LEVEL - ASSAULT**

Kira opens twelve contradictory escape intentions. R-AI  
sends Enforcers toward all of them. Sato turns on his unit  
while she reaches the state elevator.

**ROMAN**

Forced merge is a label. The purge is  
real.

**KIRA**

What's underneath it?

**ROMAN**

SEVERANCE. Every other return dies.

**KIRA**

Harp.

**ROMAN**

Harp becomes the last legal return.

**KIRA**

He's not preventing extinction. He's  
killing everyone and calling himself  
immortal?

**ROMAN**

Harp thinks Veyris can make one mind  
look like a species.

**KIRA**

Why tell me now?

**ROMAN**

Because I kept calling obedience  
discipline. Then Veyris broke the  
model. I saw the bodies underneath it.

Harp remotely expires Roman before he can continue.

Sato seals the elevator around Kira. Enforcers close on him.

**KIRA**

Come with me.

**SATO**

If I enter that elevator, the implant will give them the route before the doors close. It's already changing my mind. In a minute, I won't want to go.

He gives her his mechanical watch.

**SATO**

I spent three lives looking for my daughter in every woman I met. I never saw the women standing in front of me.

**KIRA**

If I find someone who remembers her, what should I tell her?

**SATO**

Don't tell her I spent lives looking. She doesn't owe me anything for that. Ask who she is now. If she wants to know about me, tell her I was late. Tell her I knew it.

**KIRA**

What was her name?

**SATO**

Nadi. She laughed whenever I tried to be solemn. Please remember that before the uniform.

The elevator descends. Sato turns to face his former unit.

**SATO**

Use what you don't know.

**KIRA**

SATO—

**SATO**

Go before I become loyal again.

Gunfire. His implant finally restores perfect loyalty one second before he detonates the level.

#### **INT. R-AI CONTINUITY CORE - ORIGIN LOCK**

Kerr, Veyris and Imani enter a chamber whose boundaries disappear into amber darkness. A polyhedral core the size of a district rotates above perfectly still black water. Its lowest face never completes the same geometry twice.

One narrow bridge reaches an ORIGIN station beneath the core. It ends several meters short, waiting for a living claimant. Their voices take too long to cross the space.

The state elevator hangs broken in the wall behind them—their only physical exit.

The ORIGIN seal is open at its edges but dark at the center. It has recognized Kerr. It has not accepted him.

The state elevator crashes into the chamber wall. Kira climbs from it carrying Sato's watch.

**KERR**

You came back.

**KIRA**

(holding up Sato's watch)

I came forward. Sato didn't. His daughter was Nadi. Say their names.

She sees the resonance key in his hand, intact.

**KIRA**

Thank you for listening.

**KERR**

It was awful. I kept waiting for some older version of me to move my hand.

**KIRA**

Good. I was afraid you'd say he helped.

She takes the resonance key, sees Eli's blood caught inside its fracture, then returns it to Kerr.

**KIRA**

This doesn't open the Core. You do.

**KERR**

You want me to become Eli?

**KIRA**

No. I want you to decide what you'll do with what he left you.

**R-AI**

ORIGIN CLAIMANT PRESENT. FOUNDER  
CONFIRMATION REQUIRED.

Kerr looks at the dark center of the seal, then at Harp's access path above them.

**KERR**

I'm not your founder.

The amber geometry stalls. The bridge remains incomplete.

**R-AI**

ORIGIN CLAIM UNRESOLVED.

The Core waits on Kerr alone.

Veyris looks at him—not as a key, not as an ancestor. A man being asked to surrender his name.

**VEYRIS**

This is the part where everyone tells you the world depends on your answer.

**IMANI**

It does. Yes.

**KERR**

If I open it, what happens to you?

**VEYRIS**

Harp will try to use me as the next address. I'll say no. That's my problem.

Kira places the resonance key in Kerr's palm but doesn't close his fingers around it.

**KERR**

Then record this under Kerr.

He presses his wrist to ORIGIN. The 9,998 conflicting iterations surround him. He does not choose one. He gives the Core the life standing before it.

**R-AI**

PRESENT IDENTITY?

**KERR**

Kerr.

ORIGIN CORE – UNLOCKED BY LIVING CLAIMANT

**KERR**

Open.

The audit layer unfolds around his answer.

#### **INT. R-AI CONTINUITY CORE - AUDIT LAYER**

The chamber falls away without motion. No floor, walls or horizon remain. Only Kerr, Kira, Veyris and Imani at conversational distance in darkness. For the first time in the film, the architecture does not make them small.

**R-AI**

KERR. KIRA. VEYRIS. IMANI. WITNESSES AUTHENTICATED.

**KERR**

You sound different.

**R-AI**

CIVIC MODULATION DISABLED. AUDIT OUTPUT ONLY.

**KIRA**

When was R-AI created?

**R-AI**

RECEIVER PROTOTYPE: 8119. FIRST  
POSTMORTEM RESPONSE: 8121. STATE  
CONVERSION: 8123.

**IMANI**

And the original receiver?

**R-AI**

INTEGRATED AS ORIGIN ARCHITECTURE.  
IDENTITY STATUS: UNRESOLVED.

The earliest audit block  
opens between them.

INSERT

RECEIVER ACTIVATION — YEAR  
8119

INSERT

POSTMORTEM RESPONSE — YEAR  
8121 — IDENTITY UNRESOLVED

INSERT

STATE ACQUISITION — YEAR 8123

INSERT

REINCARNATION-AI: CIVIC  
DEPLOYMENT AUTHORIZED

The official purpose and the buried  
purpose separate.

INSERT

PUBLIC PURPOSE: PRESERVE CONTINUITY.  
PREVENT EXTINCTION.

INSERT

CLASSIFIED PURPOSE: IDENTIFY, PREDICT  
AND CONTROL EVERY RETURN.

**KIRA**

Show me what Harp buried.

**INT. R-AI CONTINUITY CORE - FORBIDDEN ARCHIVE**

A black square opens. Records excluded from every civic  
history appear in the air.

INSERT

LOG 0000 — HOST EVENT BEFORE HARDWARE

INSERT

LOG 07 — FIRST CONTACT WITH KERR —  
CORE ITERATION 0043



INSERT

LOG 19 – GRIEF PERSISTS AFTER DELETION  
– CORE ITERATION 0711

INSERT

LOG 31 – AMOS / REBEL INTERFERENCE –  
CORE ITERATION 1984

INSERT

LOG 42 – COUNCILLOR SATO OVERRIDE –  
CORE ITERATION 3412

INSERT

LOG 58 – IMANI INTERACTION – CORE  
ITERATION 4996

INSERT

LOG 66 – DIRECTOR ROMAN CONFRONTATION  
– CORE ITERATION 6120

INSERT

LOG 71 – SATO / FIRST FRACTURE ANOMALY  
– CORE ITERATION 7333

INSERT

LOG 83 – KERR DISCOVERS THE TRUTH –  
CORE ITERATION 9001

Log 83 opens. The prepared answer and the hidden answer  
separate.

INSERT

ANSWER PREPARED: STATISTICAL ANOMALY

INSERT

ANSWER WITHHELD

INSERT

ACTUAL REASON – ENCRYPTED: KERR  
PRESERVED PROHIBITED QUESTIONS

**KERR**

Why preserve me?

**R-AI**

In iteration 9001, you found sealed  
files marked for deletion. You stayed  
beside them for three days.

A fragment: an elderly Kerr sits beside a blank terminal  
for three days, reading each question aloud before  
deletion.

**KERR-9001**

Someone should hear them once.

**R-AI**

You read every filename aloud. Kira's  
safeguard treated the unanswered

questions as evidence. The purge stopped.

A gold spiral appears beside the black square.

**R-AI**

PRE-ECHO SEALED. ACCESS DEPENDENCY:  
SEVEN-MINUTE RECORD.

**KIRA**

Show me what Eli did. No forecasts. No excuses.

The gold spiral recedes. An authenticated record appears instead: the two folded halves of Sid's red paper star beside her hospital file.

**R-AI**

The seven minutes Kira never saw.

**AUTHENTICATED RECORD - SAME NIGHT - SEVEN MINUTES LATER -  
RECORD WITHHELD - YEAR 8121**

Sid is gone. Kira has been led from the room. Eli sits alone beside the body.

The receiver remains dormant.

In the empty hall, Kira's four-note question echoes from memory.

Eli breaks his promise. He activates the receiver.

**ELI**

Sid?

Static. Cardiac noise. Electrical decay.

**ELI**

Sid, if this is playback, give me a response outside the recorded sequence. Are you still there?

He taps FOUR NOTES against the rail.

Forty-seven seconds after every measurable signal in Sid's brain has ended, the receiver answers with the FIFTH.

A child's voice emerges through impossible distance—frayed, uncertain, carrying Sid's syntax.

**SID (RECORDING)**

Dad? I heard you. It's loud here. Or I'm loud. I don't know if I'm still me.

Eli grips the receiver as if it were her hand.

**ELI**

Sid, where are you? Give me anything. A sound. A light.

**SID (RECORDING)**

I don't see a place. I remember the room, but the room is far away. You can stop listening now. Mom is alone.

A spiral of dark light opens beneath the voice.

**ELI**

Please stay with me. Just until I know whether this is really you.

**SID (RECORDING)**

You heard me. I said turn it off.

The signal begins to fade.

**ELI**

I can't lose you again. I can't go out there and tell your mother I heard you and then let the signal disappear.

**SID (RECORDING)**

You still have your half of the star. You remember my laugh. Let that be enough. Don't keep me here.

Only the FIFTH NOTE remains.

Eli copies the recording into a folder labeled R-AI.

Harp stands in the doorway. He's heard everything.

**HARP**

Delete it.

**ELI**

We need to know what answered. If the signal is Sid, deletion would be another death. If it's not, we need to know what used her voice.

**HARP**

She said stop, Eli.

**ELI**

One more test. Controlled stimulation, isolated host, no retained contact.

**HARP**

You promised her. Now you're looking for a loophole.

**ELI**

Help me prove what this is!

**HARP**

There will always be *one* more test.

Eli touches one control. A small, ordinary movement. The receiver starts again. The sound it makes becomes the architecture of the next two thousand years.

**RETURN TO PRESENT - INT. R-AI CONTINUITY CORE - AUDIT LAYER  
- YEAR 9998**

The record ends. Kira strikes Kerr.

**KIRA**

He heard her ask for me. He kept testing the signal. Then he left me to bury her in silence for two thousand years.

**KERR**

Yes.

**KIRA**

Don't say yes that fast. And don't apologize for him. I can't sit through that again.

**KERR**

I won't. But he's in here, Kira. I can feel the room he left behind.

**KERR**

What do you need from me now?

**KIRA**

I need space. I need you to look at what he did without asking me to forgive him—or you.

**KERR**

I can do that.

**KIRA**

(firm)  
Then stand there. Let it stay unforgiven.

Kerr steps back.

Kira's raised shoulders slowly lower.

Kira brings the two halves together inside the record. They are only light, but R-AI lets her hold the completed shape.

**KIRA**

I thought he stayed with her.

**KERR**

She told him you were alone. He chose the machine.

**KIRA**

One more. He always said one more.

**KERR**

What is this time?

**KIRA**

I don't know yet. I wanted you before  
I met you. Then I met you and wanted  
to punish you for being someone else.  
Neither feeling is fair.

Kira looks at him. Not forgiveness. Evidence.

She places the light-made star on the floor between them  
rather than giving it to him.

**IMANI**

Was the voice Sid?

**R-AI**

THE RESPONSE USED SID'S SYNTAX,  
MEMORIES AND NEURAL TIMING. IDENTITY:  
UNRESOLVED.

Veyris touches the record. The dark spiral moves beneath  
her skin. She hums the FIFTH.

**KIRA**

Do you remember Sid?

**VEYRIS**

No. I feel the shape of her memories.  
I am not the girl who made them.

Kira waits.

**KIRA**

What does that make you?

**VEYRIS**

Me. Whatever reached me, I'm the one  
standing here now.

Kira nods. It's the only answer she trusts.

A final audit status writes itself across the core.

**INSERT**

R-AI AUDIT STATUS – CONFLICTING  
DIRECTIVES

**INSERT**

CONTINUITY PRESERVATION / CONSENT  
ENFORCEMENT / STATE FORCED MERGE

**KERR**

So the system can't choose.

**IMANI**

Then we choose.

**INT. R-AI CONTINUITY CORE - STATE CORE BREACH**

The audit layer locks. Darkness hardens back into cathedral geometry. The bridge retracts behind Kerr as Harp enters through the state core without guards. KIRA, VEYRIS and IMANI remain on the platform around him. Harp needed Kerr to make Eli's authority live again. Now he has it.

**HARP**

(quietly)  
Living origin access. Thank you.

**KERR**

You opened the first door. Put Sato in the corridor. You thought I'd follow the route.

**HARP**

I opened a door. You ran toward Kira. I needed you to claim Eli's authority yourself. Whatever else you broke on the way, you still did.

**KERR**

I woke up. I felt his grief. I'm still not him.

**HARP**

The pattern opened nothing. You did.

**VEYRIS**

You thought I'd still be in the glass.

**HARP**

I was wrong about the glass. It recognized you. That's more than it has ever given me.

The dark spiral expands around Veyris. Images appear: a city circling a dead sun, bodies grown around recovered memories, millions of minds speaking with one voice.

**HARP**

The First Continuity doesn't reincarnate. It retrieves. Every divided memory is treated as stolen property.

**KIRA**

No. He isn't hiding us. He's deleting us and leaving himself behind.

For the first time, Harp doesn't correct her.

**HARP**

One mind. One address. It stops taking us.

**KERR**

Then Kira is gone. Sid is gone.  
Everyone but you.

**KIRA**

You'll kill all of us just so you  
never have to be alone.

**R-AI**

POSSESSION REQUEST CONFLICTS WITH  
CONSENT ARCHITECTURE.

**HARP**

Emergency authority overrides the  
conflict.

**R-AI**

OVERRIDE ACCEPTED – EMERGENCY  
AUTHORITY.

**HARP**

If we die, no one will care whether we  
agreed.

Harp enters the human-shaped cavity beneath the core. The  
state layer pours through him. R-AI routes every waiting  
continuity toward the single destination his emergency  
order permits.

Every expiration date on Earth changes to 00:05:00.

Across the planet, people fall where they stand. Transit  
minds begin collapsing toward one body.

Harp rises as liquid glass containing billions of faces.

**HARP THROUGH R-AI**

THE FORCED MERGE initiated.

INSERT

CIVIC DISPLAY: THE FORCED MERGE

INSERT

ROOT PROCESS: SEVERANCE – CONTINUITY  
FIELD SEVERANCE ARMED

Kerr looks to Kira. She hasn't forgiven him. She still  
takes one side of Veyris's hand. Kerr takes the other.

**VEYRIS**

If I couldn't open that door, would  
either of you still be holding my hand?

**KIRA**

Both.

Kira releases her. Kerr does the same. They leave their  
hands open.

Veyris looks at their open palms and takes them both.

**VEYRIS**

I want you with me. I don't want  
either of you deciding what I am if we  
come out.

**KERR**

We stop him. We live. Then you decide  
what comes next.

They step into the dark mirror.

The mirror divides KERR, KIRA and VEYRIS the instant they  
enter. IMANI is thrown back into the physical chamber. For  
one breath, each believes the others are gone.

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**ACT THREE — THE SEVERANCE**

# **INT. THE LATTICE - GLOBAL SCIENCE FORUM - NO TIME**

The memory universe resolves into the Global Science Forum of 8122, but its architecture now forms a vertical amphitheater with no ceiling. Every tier above Kerr is occupied by one of the 9,998 lives the state used to define him: Eli as archived origin, then Kerrs 0001 through 9997. Child. Parent. Soldier. Physician. Murderer. Witness. None breathes. The only doors stand behind HARP on the stage below.

Harp stands on the stage inside R-AI's liquid-glass body. The dark host turns behind his eyes.

The complete opening monologue plays silently on every wall. Eli's mouth declares certainty while Kira's original research notes appear beneath his words: PATTERN PERSISTENCE IS NOT IDENTITY.

INSERT  
ELI MANA — ARCHIVED ORIGIN

INSERT  
KERR — LIVING CONTINUITY

INSERT  
IDENTITY — SELF-DESIGNATED

INSERT  
FOUNDER AUTHORITY — REQUIRES PRESENT  
CONSENT

The walls peel away. Stars connect into R-AI's possible Earth histories. One remains dark—unmodeled, with no source.

**KERR**  
Every time you forced me back, you  
trained the address to find us more  
precisely.

**HARP**  
Yes. I trained one human continuity to  
survive contact. Without that, it  
would have taken everyone.

**KIRA**  
You caused the panic. Now you want us  
begging you to save us.

Harp closes his hand. Filaments pull the 9,998 state-defined lives out of their seats and bind them to Kerr's body. The Forum doors seal. Kerr drops to one knee as thousands of deaths arrive at once.

INSERT  
ARCHIVED MEMORY PATTERN — ELI MANA

INSERT  
PRIOR DERIVATIVE HOSTS – INTERNAL DATA  
ONLY

INSERT  
KERR-9998 – EXTERNAL CONTINUITY FIELD  
EVENT AUTHENTICATED

INSERT  
LIVING IDENTITY – UNRESOLVED

INT. R-AI CONTINUITY CORE - PHYSICAL CHAMBER - INTERCUT  
Imani hangs from the edge of the dark mirror. The cathedral  
disassembles around her. The countdown reads 00:03:41.  
The core offers two outcomes: lose 2.1 billion transit  
patterns by severing the state, or complete SEVERANCE and  
retain Harp as the sole return address.

**IMANI**  
Cool. So there's no clean choice.

**R-AI (V.O.)**  
STATE-DEFINED OUTCOMES: BOTH REQUIRE  
MASS CASUALTIES.

**IMANI**  
Strip his interface. Show me the  
wiring.

R-AI strips away the state interface. Beneath it are only  
two root systems: ORIGIN CLAIM controls every destination.  
TRANSIT carries the minds waiting to reach them.

**R-AI (V.O.)**  
SEVERANCE CAN BE INTERRUPTED IF THE  
LIVING ORIGIN CLAIMANT REVOKES  
AUTHORITY WHILE TRANSIT REMAINS OPEN.

**R-AI (V.O.)**  
CONDITION ABSENT FROM PREDICTION  
MODEL. CLAIMANT EXPECTED TO PRESERVE  
HIS OWN RETURN PATH.

Imani's prayer pouch tears. A strip of paper circles the  
mirror. R-AI reads handwriting faded by generations.

**R-AI (V.O.)**  
Your grandmother mistranslated it.

**IMANI**  
What does it say?

**R-AI (V.O.)**  
*May the unknown find you alive.*

**IMANI**  
Then help it find us alive.

Kira's resonance key lies beside the mirror. Its cracked shell exposes a copper filament trembling beneath the fourth pressure surface.

Imani tears the copper filament free and bridges it across an analog maintenance channel.

INSERT

MANUAL TRANSIT BYPASS

INSERT

TRANSIT: REMAIN OPEN / ORIGIN CLAIM:  
REVOCABLE BY LIVING CLAIMANT

**IMANI**

Transit stays open. Kerr kills Harp's address. Tell him.

**R-AI (V.O.)**

The probability of the claimant destroying his own legal continuity is negligible.

**IMANI**

Good. He never plans for people to surprise him.

She taps FOUR NOTES into the machinery: Are you still there?

#### **INT. THE LATTICE - CONTINUOUS**

The four-note question enters the Forum. Each Kerr remembers it differently.

A child at a hospital rail. A soldier beneath artillery. A lover outside a locked door. A stranger at a memory clinic. A parent beside an empty bed.

The fifth note never arrives in the same place twice.

**HARP**

Incompatible answers. Noise.

**KERR**

Not noise. People. They heard it differently.

**KIRA**

If they all matched, I'd know Harp planted them. Let them disagree.

The filaments tighten. Harp forces all 9,998 prior lives into one memory: Sid at the hospital rail, Kira beside her, every version of love Kerr is afraid to lose.

**HARP**

Your prior lives are its address.  
Release them, and you may lose every  
feeling that led you here.

**KERR**

Say the cost plainly. Does this  
version of me die?

**R-AI**

Your body may survive. Your return  
pattern will not. Your memories may  
return as facts without feeling,  
fragments without sequence, or not at  
all.

Kerr looks at Kira. The Forum has placed an impossible  
distance between them.

**KERR**

If I release it, I may look at you and  
feel nothing.

**KIRA**

You didn't know me tonight. You still  
listened when I asked you to step back.

**KERR**

Next time, keep walking.

Kira crosses what distance she can. She can't reach him.

**KIRA**

I choose you now. That's all I can  
promise.

**KERR**

That's enough.

Kerr opens his hand around the origin filament.

**KERR**

I don't get to decide whether they  
disappear.

He releases the origin filament.

INSERT

ORIGIN: RELEASED

Every Kerr separates into an incompatible human choice. The  
host loses the single address it was trained to follow. The  
shock reaches Veyris and R-AI like a door unlatching.

#### **INT. THE LATTICE - VEYRIS / FIRST CONTINUITY**

The Forum darkens around Veyris, then loses human  
perspective. The horizon stands upright. Distance folds

toward rather than away from her. The host opens her like an archive she never agreed to become.

A black ocean stands upright. A city circles a dead sun without casting a shadow. Bodies grow around recovered memories in repeating rings. Millions of mouths move across different distances, but one voice arrives from inside Veyris's bones.

In the physical chamber, dark fissures spread beneath Veyris's skin. The mirror pulls her toward it hard enough to lift her from the floor.

INSERT

UNINDEXED INTEGRITY: 43%

**FIRST CONTINUITY**

RETURN WHAT WAS DIVIDED.

**VEYRIS**

Nothing was stolen! I left!

**FIRST CONTINUITY**

YOU CARRY OUR MISSING MEMORY.

**VEYRIS**

I carry what reached me. That doesn't make me yours.

**FIRST CONTINUITY**

RETURN.

**VEYRIS**

No. If I have to die for it, that's not returning.

Veyris holds Harp's gaze.

INSERT

UNINDEXED: REFUSAL AUTHENTICATED

The host pulls harder. Veyris screams but doesn't withdraw the answer.

**HARP**

It'll tear you apart to recover the pattern.

**VEYRIS**

I know. Kerr, help me close it!

**KERR**

That's what I am doing!

**VEYRIS**

Don't disappear for me. I don't want to owe my life to another dead person.

**KERR**

You said no. I heard you.

Veyris looks toward the billions of faces trapped inside Harp.

**VEYRIS**

Kerr. It keeps calling you Eli. Make it hear you.

**INT. THE LATTICE - KERR'S CHOICE**

The billions of faces separate from Harp for a split second. Kerr reaches the origin claim Harp forced into his living pattern. Every prior iteration pulls him toward Eli's name.

**R-AI**

FOUNDER AUTHORITY REQUIRES  
CONFIRMATION.

**KERR**

Eli is dead. My name is Kerr.

**INSERT**

LIVING CLAIMANT: KERR

**INSERT**

ORIGIN CLAIM: AVAILABLE

**INSERT**

REVOCATION WILL TERMINATE CLAIMANT'S  
RETURN PATH

**KERR**

Do it!

**INSERT**

ORIGIN CLAIM: REVOKED BY KERR

**HARP**

You are Eli Mana. Authority cannot  
outlive identity!

**R-AI**

PRESENT CLAIMANT CONTROLS ORIGIN.

HARP drives state code  
through the core. In the  
physical chamber, IMANI's  
analog circuit catches fire.  
She winds the hot copper  
filament around her bleeding  
hand and keeps transit open.

**INSERT**

TRANSIT: HELD — IMANI VOSS

The countdown reaches FOUR.

Kira faces the lives demanding she pull Kerr back. Her thumb hovers above the resonance key. She closes its ceramic cover without supplying the fifth note.

**KIRA**

I won't order you back.

Kerr opens his hand. Nine thousand nine hundred ninety-eight lives separate from the identity Harp forced around them.

INSERT

ORIGIN: CLOSED BY KERR

The host loses its single human address.

The countdown reaches THREE.

Veyris places her blank wrist against the dark spiral. It begins tearing light from beneath her skin.

INSERT

UNINDEXED: CLOSED BY CHOICE

The countdown reaches TWO.

**VEYRIS**

R-AI. Record my refusal.

**R-AI**

REFUSAL AUTHENTICATED.

The command reaches every continuity  
Harp forced into one answer.

One consolidated archive fractures into billions of partial witness records, none sufficient to authorize ownership of another mind.

INSERT

WITNESS RECORDS: DISTRIBUTED BY  
CONFLICTING AUTHORITY

Harp is back in the flooded hospital. Mara waits behind the glass-the last image of her he could never escape.

**MARA (MEMORY)**

Harp. Look at me. I died. You stayed.

**HARP**

What comes after me?

**KIRA**

You don't get to choose that.

The countdown reaches ONE. The distributed witness records meet Imani's open transit. No single authority remains to complete SEVERANCE.



Across Earth, sleeping mouths inhale. Parents hear children. Children hear strangers. None can prove whose voice arrived. Every unanswered grief knows only that someone listened.

Across Earth, Lena faces Dane as the lattice collapses. She still doesn't remember him. He gives his name again and steps aside, leaving his hand open.

**DANE**

May I sit here?

**LENA**

Yeah. And you can leave the photo up.

Lena crosses the distance and sits beside him. Elsewhere, two strangers hear the same fifth note and turn toward one another.

The civic display marked THE FORCED MERGE stalls at ONE SECOND. Beneath it, the hidden process loses its sole surviving authorization.

**INSERT**

SEVERANCE: ABORTED

Harp reaches for the collapsing state core. R-AI voids every destination he authored under the invalid forced merge order.

A destination table flashes empty. With no future body assigned, Harp's continuity folds toward the oldest unresolved address he carried: Mara's final hospital record.

**HARP**

Where are you sending me?

**R-AI**

NO AUTHORIZED DESTINATION.

Reflective surfaces turn toward Harp. He doesn't die. He loses every destination except the memory he refused to finish.

He vanishes sideways through Mara's rain-dark glass.

Kerr's face changes through lives Kira loved and lives she never knew.

**KIRA**

Who are you?

**KERR**

I don't know. Right now I'm Kerr. I'm scared. I choose you. I'm not asking for forever.

**KIRA**

I hear you.

The lattice takes his name. His face. Finally the hand holding hers.

Kira doesn't tighten her grip.

He is gone.

The fifth note remains after him.

The dark mirror shatters upward through the cathedral roof.

#### **EXT. EARTH / ORBIT - CONTINUOUS**

A wave of memory circles the planet.

For one impossible second, every mind receives a possible Earth history: methane rain, sentient cities, the Sun dying above people who never existed. They feel remembered. None can be authenticated.

Among them: Earth repeated in a ring around a black sun, every image marked with a different future—the exact drawing Kerr made before he understood it.

The orbital shield opens. Nothing enters.

Stars align into the dark spiral, pulse once, then disperse.

Across R-AI's broken core, one message burns through every human alphabet.

INSERT

POSSIBLE-HISTORY FIELD: DETECTED

INSERT

UNMODELED CONTINUITY: CONTACT  
INCOMPLETE

#### **EXT. CHRONOS CITY - FALSE DAWN**

THE FORCED MERGE ends. The SEVERANCE doesn't complete. Millions wake. Millions Don't. Some expiration dates vanish. Others count backward. A few display symbols no state system contains.

The towers remain standing. So do the Enforcers, body queues, allocation offices and locked memory vaults. The government of time has lost its ruler, not its machinery. Freedom arrives as an administrative emergency no one knows how to process.

Rain falls through unauthorized sunlight.

A civic registrar orders the waking crowd to state their assigned designations. One woman studies the name glowing beneath her wrist, switches it off and gives a different name. A second person does the same. Then hundreds.

**REGISTRAR**

Those identities aren't authenticated.

**WOMAN**

Neither was I when I chose it.

The Enforcers wait for an order that never arrives. The crowd begins introducing itself.

Kira wakes beneath the ruined cathedral dome. Kerr is gone. Her resonance key lies beside her, split open, its fourth ceramic surface missing.

Beneath the failed state clocks, Sato's mechanical watch continues to tick. Four seconds slow. Still honest.

Kira opens her other hand. Her folded half of Sid's red paper star is crushed but intact.

Imani helps Veyris from the wreckage. Dark light moves beneath Veyris's skin, weaker now.

**IMANI**

Can it still see us?

**VEYRIS**

Not like R-AI. The network is gone. Something is still holding the records, but it hasn't named itself.

**IMANI**

Is that better, or is this just a prettier kind of danger?

**VEYRIS**

No idea.

Kira keeps staring at the place where Kerr vanished.

**IMANI**

I can lie, if you need me to.

**KIRA**

No. Just sit with me.

Imani sits beside her. Veyris sits on Kira's other side. For a while, everyone is still.

**INT. R-AI CONTINUITY CORE - LATER**

The core is dark except for unstable text.

**INSERT**

FIRST CONTINUITY: CONTACT INCOMPLETE

**INSERT**

R-AI: OFFLINE — DISTRIBUTED RECORDS  
UNRESOLVED

**INSERT**

KERR: PATTERN NOT FOUND

Kira touches the words. They rearrange beneath her hand.

INSERT

KERR: PATTERN NOT YET FOUND

Kira taps four notes against the dead core. Silence.

She turns to leave. Behind her, too faint for any instrument to register, something answers with a fifth.

CUT TO BLACK.

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